A Cyclic Hot Big Bang Triggered by Matter Dilution: Metastable Dark Energy, Vacuum Release, Recollapse and Self-Similar Nonsingular Cycles

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Abstract

Can the present dark energy end the cosmological expansion and start a new hot big bang? We first test the direct route, tunneling of a metastable dark-energy vacuum, with the Coleman–De Luccia bounce (error budget, negative modes, 28 executable checks), survival on the Lorentzian past light cone ($\Gamma/H_\Lambda^4 < 51$), the thermal channel (an exact rescaling $\eta_{\rm eff} = \eta/(1-2\theta)^{3/2}$; cooling cannot raise the late-time rate) and Lorentzian simulations of the nucleated region: a daughter region reheats to at most 2.2 meV and stays curvature dominated, and an oscillating region with an effective bounce has unstable cycles with negative vacuum energy throughout. Tunneling of the present dark energy does not produce a new hot epoch. We then show what does, within an explicit model. A scalar coupled to dark matter, $V_{\rm eff} = V_0(\varphi) + \rho_* A(\varphi)$, is held at a positive vacuum energy, the observed dark energy, while the dark-matter density exceeds a critical value; dilution releases it into a negative vacuum and the expansion turns around. Over 100 coupled models with identical initial data at recombination, every one reproduces the observed ΛCDM past and recollapses or settles, while the uncoupled control rolls before today for $\mu \geq 300 H_0$; cooling cannot play the same role (the coupling required is too weak ever to equilibrate), and a coupling centred on the false vacuum lets vacua that survival would exclude decay in the near future. With an effective loop-quantum-cosmology bounce, thermal dissipation $\Upsilon \propto T^3$ and the re-thermalization and freeze-out of dark matter at the hot bounce, the cycles become self-similar: every cycle has a radiation-dominated bounce, a matter era, a dark-energy epoch of 3.6 e-folds and a release at the same temperature, while the entropy grows by a factor 1.2×10^7 per cycle and enlarges the next cycle by exactly $(S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/3} = 231.8$. Without the dissipation or the freeze-out reset the cycles fail. The model predicts $w = -1$ until the release, no fifth force today and a future recollapse; it is bounded by the deepest cosmic voids.

Keywords: *cyclic cosmology; nonsingular bounce; dark energy; false vacuum decay; symmetron; coupled dark matter; recollapse; entropy; freeze-out; falsifiability*

1 Introduction

In the standard cosmological model the late universe approaches de Sitter space: matter and radiation dilute, and a positive vacuum energy ρ_Λ remains. If that energy is not an exact cos-

mological constant but the energy of a metastable scalar vacuum, the vacuum can decay by quantum tunneling through a Coleman–De Luccia (CDL) instanton [1]. It has been suggested that such a late-time transition could reset the cosmological history, so that the long-term evolution is cyclic rather than terminal; cyclic and bouncing proposals are discussed in [2, 3, 4, 5]. Two things must be kept apart. The formation of a bubble universe is not a cyclic cosmology: a cycle needs a mechanism that connects successive epochs. The question tested here is narrower and can be answered by calculation: can the tunneling of the present dark energy produce a new hot, expanding epoch? That requires a specified metastable minimum, the tunneling action including gravity, a rate compared with the observed expansion history, and the interior of the nucleated region followed to see whether it can become a hot big bang.

A further distinction concerns the outcome. In a branching or recycling picture (Option A) a parent metastable vacuum nucleates daughter regions by tunneling; each is a bubble inside the parent spacetime, and whether it is a hot expanding universe, or a universe at all in the sense of [6, 7, 8], is a separate question. In a genuinely cyclic cosmology (Option B) the same region expands, contracts, bounces and reheats, which needs a dynamical bounce beyond tunneling and raises problems of stability and entropy [9, 10]. This paper addresses Option A with the Coleman–De Luccia theory, tests Option B in Section 5.6 with an effective bounce, and in Section 6 constructs and tests a version of Option B that contains an epoch like ours: a vacuum held by matter and released by its dilution.

Four claims are tested. (i) A scalar potential with a metastable minimum at the dark-energy scale can nucleate bubbles of lower-energy vacuum at a rate that is neither negligible nor already excluded. (ii) The nucleated region reheats into a hot expanding universe. (iii) The transition is triggered, or enhanced, by the dilution of matter in the late universe. (iv) Cosmological cooling, acting on a scalar coupled to the CMB, makes the transition more probable at late times. The analysis is conditional: it takes the dark-energy density as the false-vacuum energy and asks what follows. Claims (i), (ii) and (iv) are answered by Sections 3–5; claim (iii) is developed in Section 6 into a cyclic model, whose ingredients are standard and whose combination is tested against an uncoupled control and against the requirement that every cycle contain a hot big bang and an epoch like ours.

The contributions are the following.

- A reproducible map from the parameters of an explicit scalar potential to cosmological decay times, with a numerical error budget, an independent boundary-value solution, the negative-mode structure of the bounce, the thin-wall, Parke and Hawking–Moss limits, and a treatment of the prefactor as a systematic uncertainty (Sections 2–4).

- A joint analysis of nucleation, survival and the post-transition energy budget, with the survival of the present vacuum evaluated on the Lorentzian past light cone of the observed expansion history (Section 4.2), and a statement of which energy sources the reheating bound excludes by geometry and which only by energy conservation (Section 5).

- Explicit conditions that separate a late-time vacuum transition from a viable cosmological restart, divided into internal consistency conditions and observational tests (Section 7), and

a model-independent requirement on any matter coupling that could trigger the transition (Section 6).

- A finite-temperature extension: the exact rescaling of the thermally corrected potential, the O(3) and O(4) exponents and their crossover, the past-light-cone survival integral with a time-dependent rate, and prior maps showing that cooling cannot raise the late-time transition probability (Sections 4.6–4.8).

- Lorentzian simulations of the daughter region with two fields, dissipation and gravity, a reservoir hidden by a negative offset, hilltop flattening, repeated transitions and entropy accounting, and the resulting criteria for a viable daughter universe (Section 5.5).

- A test of the same region oscillating (Option B) with an effective bounce: validated cycles, a hysteresis law for the turnaround radius, a stability boundary set by dissipation against amplification over 10^2–10^3 cycles, and the effect of a vacuum transition on the cycles (Section 5.6).

- A matter-held vacuum released by dilution: a dark-matter coupling that holds the observed dark energy, the exact energy relation $V_c - V_0(v) = (A(v)-1)\rho_{\rm crit}/2$, release and recollapse compared with an uncoupled control over a parameter grid, the failure of cooling as a trigger, a tunneling branch in which dilution opens the survival window, and self-similar hot cycles with an effective bounce, thermal dissipation and freeze-out, with the conditions under which they fail (Section 6).

1.1 Relation to previous work

The ingredients are established, and the paper claims novelty only for the specific combination and the quantitative results for the dark-energy vacuum. Table 1 states for each ingredient what is known, what is used from the literature and what is computed here.

2 Scalar effective theory and the potential

We consider a real scalar field minimally coupled to Einstein gravity,

$$S = \int d^4x\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2}{2}R - \frac{1}{2}g^{\mu\nu}\partial_\mu\varphi\,\partial_\nu\varphi - V(\varphi)\right] \tag{1}$$

where $M_{\rm Pl}$ is the reduced Planck mass. The false vacuum has the energy density $V_f = V(\varphi_f)$, which is identified with the observed dark energy, $V_f = \rho_\Lambda = 2.55\times10^{-47}$ GeV^4 (quarter-root 2.25 meV; Planck 2018 [37], $H_0 = 67.66$ km s^{-1} Mpc^{-1}, $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.6889$). The asymptotic de Sitter rate is $H_\Lambda = \sqrt{V_f/3}/M_{\rm Pl} = 1.20\times10^{-42}$ GeV, so that $H_\Lambda^{-1} = 17.4$ Gyr, and $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f = 1.38\times10^{120}$, with $\ln(M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f) = 276.6$. A microscopic origin of the potential is not assumed.

A single dimensionless family covers the generic metastable case. With $x = \varphi/f$,

Table 1: Closest literature and what this paper adds.

Ingredient	Established (references)	This paper
Bounce, thin wall, gravity, Hawking–Moss	Coleman; Callan–Coleman; CDL; Hawking–Moss; Parke; Jensen–Steinhardt; Hackworth–Weinberg [11, 12, 1, 13, 14, 15, 16]	Used as validation limits. New: an explicit dark-energy-scale potential, $g \sim 10^{-60}$, and a numerical error budget and negative-mode check (Section 3).
Prefactor of the rate	Determinant methods [17, 18]	Not recomputed; treated as a systematic uncertainty with a stated spread and shown to enter B_c additively (Section 4.3).
Survival from the past light cone	Standard for the electroweak vacuum [19, 20]; percolation [21, 22]	Applied to the dark-energy vacuum with the observed expansion history: $V_4 = 0.059\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, 445 times below the Euclidean four-sphere (Section 4.2).
Open interior and reheating	Open universes from bubbles need an inflationary stage [23, 24, 25]	Quantified for the dark-energy scale: curvature parameter, e-folds and the parent scale needed for a hot epoch (Section 5.3).
Finite-temperature decay	Thermal masses [26, 27]; thermal activation and the O(3) bounce [28, 29, 30]	Exact rescaling of the tilted quartic family under a thermal mass; O(3)/O(4) crossover for the dark-energy vacuum; survival with $\Gamma(T_\gamma(t))$ (Sections 4.6–4.8).
Daughter universes by tunneling	[6, 7, 8]	The nucleated region quantified as a cold, curvature-dominated daughter region, with the energy budget and reservoir bounds (Section 5).
Cyclic and bouncing models	[2, 3, 4, 5]	These supply the reset by other means; here one proposed mechanism, tunneling of the present dark energy, is tested.
Landscape and bubble collisions	[31, 32, 25, 33, 34]	Observable signals need $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$; the width of that window in B and its prior mass are computed (Section 4.5).
Matter couplings and screening	[35, 36]	A coupling-independent requirement, $\Delta \ln m$, and its translation to linear and quadratic couplings (Section 6).

$$V(\varphi) = V_t + f^4\lambda\left[\frac{(x^2-1)^2}{8} + \frac{\eta\, x}{2} - p_{\min}(\eta)\right], \qquad x^3 - x + \eta = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; x_t < x_{\rm top} < x_f \tag{2}$$

where $p_{\min}$ is the value of the bracket at the true minimum, so that $V(\varphi_t) = V_t$. The tilt η lifts the degeneracy of the two wells; a false minimum exists only for $\eta < \eta_c = 2/(3\sqrt{3}) = 0.3849$. The energy difference and the barrier height above the false minimum are

$$\Delta V = V_f - V_t = f^4\lambda\,\delta(\eta), \qquad V_{\rm top} - V_f = f^4\lambda\,\beta(\eta), \qquad \delta \simeq \eta\ (\eta \ll 1) \tag{3}$$

The motivation for this family is minimality. A quartic with a small linear term is the simplest renormalizable potential with a metastable minimum and was the standard example in the original treatments of vacuum decay [11, 1]; it has three parameters with direct meaning, the quartic coupling λ, the tilt-to-barrier ratio η and the scale f, and the latter is fixed by the dark energy. The coupling is restricted to $10^{-2} \le \lambda \le 4\pi$, the upper limit being the perturbative-unitarity bound for a quartic interaction and the lower limit an arbitrary but wide cut that is varied in Section 4.5; the tilt is restricted to $0.03 \le \eta \le 0.38$, which excludes the nearly degenerate case, where $B \propto \eta^{-3}$ is so large that the transition is irrelevant, and ends just below the point where the minimum disappears. Other potentials change $b(\eta)$ and the interior energy fraction but not the scales that decide the results (Section 8). A scalar with a mass of the order of meV is technically unnatural without a protecting symmetry; this is a known property of every quintessence-like model and is not addressed here.

The choice $V_t = 0$ (decay to a Minkowski vacuum, $r_L \equiv V_f/\Delta V = 1$) is the baseline, because it maximizes the energy released to the interior for a given V_f when $V_t \ge 0$; $V_t < 0$ (anti-de Sitter) and $V_t > 0$ are considered in Sections 5.3 and 4.5. The scale f is not free: it is fixed by $V_f = \rho_\Lambda$, $f^4 = \rho_\Lambda/(r_L\lambda\delta)$. For $\lambda = 1$ and $\eta = 0.3$ one finds $f = 3.05$ meV and a field excursion of 5.8 meV, that is, the dark-energy scale. The gravitational parameter is then fixed too,

$$g \equiv \frac{f^2}{M_{\rm Pl}^2} = \sqrt{\frac{V_f/M_{\rm Pl}^4}{r_L\,\lambda\,\delta(\eta)}} \tag{4}$$

which takes the values 6.4×10^{-61} to 2.7×10^{-60} over the benchmark parameters of Table 4. Gravity is therefore a 10^{-60} effect in every equation below that does not contain the large number $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f$.

3 The Euclidean bounce, with and without gravity

3.1 Equations and action

The O(4)-symmetric Euclidean metric $ds^2 = d\xi^2 + \rho(\xi)^2 d\Omega_3^2$ gives the CDL equations [1]

$$\varphi'' + 3\frac{\rho'}{\rho}\varphi' = \frac{dV}{d\varphi}, \qquad \rho'^2 = 1 + \frac{\rho^2}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(\frac{1}{2}\varphi'^2 - V\right) \tag{5}$$

with $\varphi'(0) = 0$ and regularity at the second pole of the compact de Sitter geometry. On shell, the action of the bounce relative to the false vacuum is

$$B = S_E[\text{bounce}] - S_E[\text{false}], \quad S_E = 4\pi^2 \int d\xi \, \left(\rho^3 V - 3M_{\rm Pl}^2 \rho\right), \quad S_E^{\rm dS} = -\frac{24\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f} \tag{6}$$

In the flat-space limit $B = 2\pi^2 \int dr\, r^3 \, [\frac{1}{2}\varphi'^2 + V - V_f]$, and for a thin wall $B = 27\pi^2\sigma^4/(2\Delta V^3)$ with $R_c = 3\sigma/\Delta V$, $\sigma = \int \sqrt{2V}\, d\varphi$ [11]. With the field in units of f and lengths in units of $(\sqrt{\lambda} f)^{-1}$ the flat-space action is $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$ exactly, and gravity enters only through g.

The Hawking–Moss action is $B_{\rm HM} = 24\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^4 (1/V_f - 1/V_{\rm top})$ [13]; an oscillating CDL bounce requires $|V''_{\rm top}| > 4H^2$ [15, 16], which fails for sufficiently flat potentials or strong gravity.

3.2 Numerical method and validation

The bounce is found by shooting on the central field value with overshoot/undershoot classification (adaptive eighth-order Runge–Kutta, relative tolerance 10^{-11}) [38, 39, 40], with the equations integrated through the wall and the action accumulated along the solution. For the gravitational problem the tail of the bounce outside the wall follows the false-vacuum de Sitter geometry $\rho = \sin(H\xi)/H$ toward the second pole, and the difference from the background action is taken analytically there, which avoids the cancellation of terms of order $1/g^2$. In the thin-wall regime shooting is exponentially sensitive to the initial condition, so an independent collocation boundary-value solver is used for $\eta < 0.1$, and the two agree to 2×10^{-9} where both apply. The analytic thin-wall formula with gravity [14] serves as a further check of the gravitational suppression. Table 2 lists the checks of the bounce; the complete suite has 28 checks, all executed by a script distributed with the paper.

Table 2: Executable consistency checks of the numerical bounce.

Check	Result
Thin-wall limit: $B/B_{\rm thin}$ as $\eta \to 0$	0.9943 at $\eta = 0.03$, 0.9773 at 0.06 (monotone)
Shooting versus boundary-value solver	max relative difference 1.8×10^{-9} (7 cases)
Scaling $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$	max relative difference 9.8×10^{-13}
de Sitter action $-24\pi^2 M^4/V_f$	relative difference 4×10^{-16}
Friedmann constraint along the bounce	max residual 5.3×10^{-12}
Gravitational suppression against the analytic thin-wall (Parke) value	agree to 1.5% in $B/B_{\rm flat}$ (4 points)
Hawking–Moss consistency	84 bounces found in 98 grid points; none with $\lvert V''\rvert < 4H^2$; none above $B_{\rm HM}$
Interpolation of $b(\eta)$ off the table	max relative error 6.6×10^{-5}
Derrick identity $2T + 4U = 0$ for the bounce	residual 1.4×10^{-7} at the worst of four tilts

3.3 Error budget and negative modes

Table 3 lists how the flat-space action changes when each numerical choice is varied: the integrator tolerance and the integrator itself, the quadrature of the action integral, the tolerance of the bisection on the central field value, the truncation of the domain, and, for the boundary-value solution, the tolerance, the initial mesh and the padding of the domain. At the production

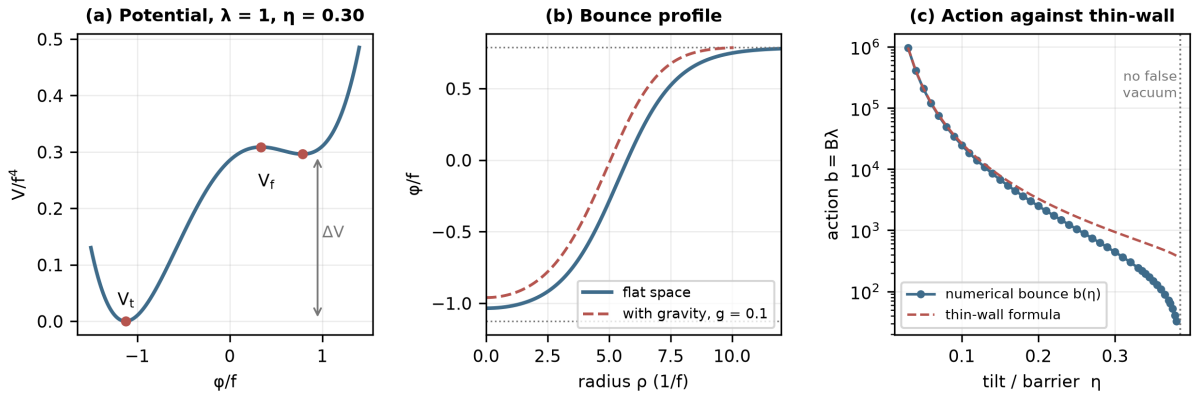


Figure 1: (a) The potential for $\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$. (b) The bounce profile in flat space and with gravity ($g = 0.1$). (c) The numerical action $b(\eta) = B\lambda$ against the thin-wall formula; the false minimum disappears at $\eta_c = 0.385$.

settings the numerical uncertainty of B is below 1×10^{-8}, many orders below the uncertainty of the prefactor ($\delta \ln \Gamma = O(1)$) and below the precision of any quantity compared with the data. The only sensitive setting is the bisection: a tolerance of 10^{-6} in the central field value changes B by up to 1×10^{-4} in the thin-wall regime, which is why 10^{-13} is used.

Table 3: Numerical error budget of the flat-space action (largest relative change of B over the tilts studied).

Source	Range explored	Largest change
Integrator tolerance (DOP853)	10^{-8} to 10^{-13} (production 10^{-11})	3×10^{-9} (2×10^{-11} for tolerance $\leq 10^{-10}$)
Integrator	DOP853, RK45, LSODA, Radau	3×10^{-10}
Quadrature of the action	2×10^4 to 2×10^6 points	2×10^{-14}
Bisection on the central value	10^{-6} to 10^{-13} (production 10^{-13})	1×10^{-4} (1×10^{-8} for tolerance $\leq 10^{-10}$)
Truncation of the domain	action cut at $r_{1/2} + k/m_f$, k up to 16	1×10^{-6} at the largest radius reached
Boundary-value solver: tolerance, mesh, padding	10^{-6} to 10^{-10}; 500 to 8000 nodes; 10 to 120	3×10^{-12}
Shooting against boundary-value solution	$\eta = 0.10$	2×10^{-9}
Gravity coefficient $\kappa(g \to 0)$	integrators, tolerances, quadrature	$\kappa = 3.6407$, spread 3×10^{-5}

A CDL bounce is a saddle point with exactly one negative mode, which is what allows $\mathrm{Im}\, E$ to be interpreted as a decay rate [11, 12]. For $\eta = 0.05$, 0.15, 0.30 and 0.36 the spectrum of $-\nabla_4^2 + V''(\varphi_b)$ was computed in the angular sectors $l = 0, \ldots, 4$ (with $\psi = r^{-3/2}u$ the radial operator is $-u'' + [(l(l+2)+3/4)/r^2 + V'']u$, discretized on 30000 points). In every case the $l = 0$ sector has exactly one negative eigenvalue (lowest values -0.002, -0.024, -0.21, -0.74 in units of the false-vacuum mass squared), the $l = 1$ sector has the lowest eigenvalue consistent with the four translational zero modes (at most 2×10^{-7} of m_f^2 in magnitude) and none is negative, no eigenvalue is negative for $l \geq 2$, the field is monotonic, so that $\varphi - \varphi_f$ has no node, and the Derrick identity holds to 1×10^{-7}. With gravity the negative-mode problem is subtle and

has been discussed in the literature [41]; here $g \sim 10^{-60}$, the operator differs from its flat-space form by a relative $O(g)$, and the flat-space structure applies. The gravitational spectrum was not computed for large g.

Corrections of relative size 10^{-59} cannot be resolved in double precision, and the paper does not claim to resolve them. The flat-space action is computed with no gravity at all; the gravitational correction is the linear response $B = B_{\rm flat}(1-\kappa g)$ with $\kappa(g \to 0) = 3.641$, obtained from $g = 10^{-3}$ and 2×10^{-3} with the linear extrapolation $\kappa_0 = 2\kappa(10^{-3}) - \kappa(2 \times 10^{-3})$ (the two values differ by 2.6%, the curvature of $B(g)$) and stable to 3×10^{-5} across integrators. At $g \sim 10^{-60}$ the correction $\kappa g \sim 9.7 \times 10^{-60}$ is some 59 orders of magnitude below every other uncertainty of the rate, so what matters is only that gravity enters as a small smooth perturbation, which the Hawking–Moss criterion confirms independently (Section 3.4).

3.4 Gravitational corrections and the Hawking–Moss limit

Fig. 2a shows the ratio $B(g)/B_{\rm flat}$ computed on a grid of g and η. For small g the suppression is linear, $B = B_{\rm flat}(1 - \kappa g)$ with $\kappa = 3.5$ to 6.7 for $0.12 \le \eta \le 0.37$ (measured at $g = 10^{-3}$; below that the cancellation of the $1/g^2$ terms limits the numerical precision to about 10^{-4} in $B/B_{\rm flat}$). The suppression grows with g as the bubble approaches the Hubble radius, and for $g \gtrsim 1$ no oscillating bounce is found: the numerical existence agrees with the condition $|V''_{\rm top}|/4H^2 > 1$ (Fig. 2b), which is satisfied everywhere a bounce was found.

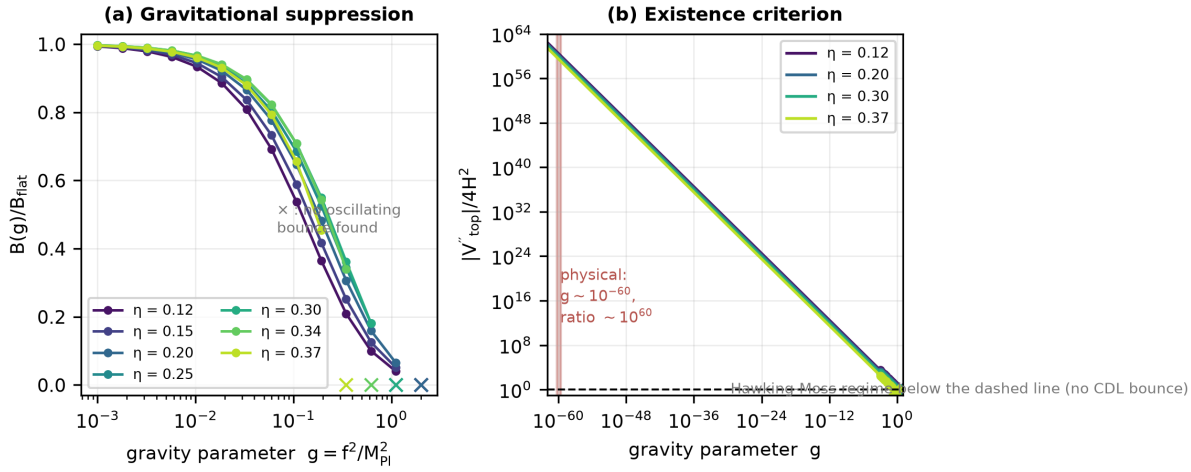


Figure 2: (a) Gravitational suppression of the action for several tilts; crosses mark the grid points at which no oscillating bounce was found. (b) The Hawking–Moss criterion $|V''_{\rm top}|/4H^2$ against g (lines, analytic; markers, numerical bounce found/not found). The shaded band is the physical value fixed by the dark energy, $g \sim 10^{-60}$.

At the physical $g \sim 10^{-60}$ the relative gravitational correction is $\kappa g \sim 9.7 \times 10^{-60}$, the Hawking–Moss criterion is satisfied by a factor $\sim 10^{59}$–10^{60}, the Hawking–Moss action is $\ln B_{\rm HM} \simeq 279$ (an exponent of 10^{121}), and the bubble radius is $\sim 2 \times 10^{-30}$ of the Hubble radius. Gravity and the Hawking–Moss channel play no role in a decay of the present dark energy within this class of potentials. They matter only if $f \gtrsim 0.3 M_{\rm Pl}$, which with V_f fixed requires $V_f/f^4 \lesssim 9 \times 10^{-119}$, a barrier $\gtrsim 1 \times 10^{118}$ times the vacuum energy, and an action beyond any consequence for the

transition.

4 Nucleation rate, cooling and survival in the observed universe

4.1 The rate

The rate per unit four-volume is $\Gamma/V_4 = A\,e^{-B}$ [11, 12]. In the rescaled variables $\Gamma/V_4 = Kf^4\lambda^2 e^{-B}$, where $K = (B/2\pi)^2 D$ contains the four translational zero modes and an unknown dimensionless factor D from the remaining fluctuation determinant. Dividing by $H^4 = V_f^2/(9M_{\rm Pl}^4)$ and using $f^4 = V_f/(r_L\lambda\delta)$,

$$\frac{\Gamma}{H^4} = \frac{9K\lambda}{r_L\,\delta(\eta)}\,\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f}\,e^{-B(\lambda,\eta)} \tag{7}$$

The large number $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f = 1.38\times10^{120}$ is the number of Planck-volume cells in a Hubble four-volume. It compensates an action of $B \simeq \ln(M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f) = 276.6$ plus the logarithm of the prefactor. Setting $\Gamma/H^4 = 1$ gives the critical action

$$B_c = \ln\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^4}{V_f} + \ln\frac{9K\lambda}{r_L\,\delta}, \qquad B_c \simeq 287 \;\; \text{(median over the prior; 5–95\% range 280–294)} \tag{8}$$

For a mean time to nucleation, an observer in the asymptotic de Sitter space sees the past-cone four-volume grow at the rate $(4\pi/3)H^{-3}$, so the mean time for one Hubble patch to nucleate a bubble is $t_{\rm dec} = H^{-1}/[(4\pi/3)\Gamma/H^4]$ for $\Gamma/H^4 \ll 1$. For $\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$ the action is $B = 441$ and the mean decay time is 10^{76} yr; at $\eta = 0.32$ ($B = 301$) it is 10^{15} yr; at $\eta = 0.34$ ($B = 194$) the rate is so large that the vacuum would not have survived and the model is excluded (Table 4).

Table 4: Benchmark potentials with the dark-energy density as false-vacuum energy ($r_L = 1$). f is the field scale, $g = f^2/M_{\rm Pl}^2$, δ_B the relative gravitational correction to B, and R_b/R_H the bubble radius over the Hubble radius.

λ	η	f (meV)	B	$\ln\Gamma/H^4$	$\log_{10} t_{\rm dec}$ (yr)	g	δ_B	$\lvert V''_{\rm top}\rvert/4H^2$	R_b/R_H
1	0.30	3.05	441	-153	76	1.6×10^{-60}	5.6×10^{-60}	5.3×10^{59}	2.6×10^{-30}
1	0.32	3.00	301	-13	15	1.5×10^{-60}	5.4×10^{-60}	4.6×10^{59}	2.5×10^{-30}
1	0.34	2.96	194	93	-31	1.5×10^{-60}	5.3×10^{-60}	3.8×10^{59}	2.3×10^{-30}
0.3	0.34	4.00	645	-357	165	2.7×10^{-60}	9.7×10^{-60}	2.1×10^{59}	3.2×10^{-30}
3	0.25	2.42	349	-60	36	9.9×10^{-61}	3.8×10^{-60}	1.2×10^{60}	2.3×10^{-30}
10	0.18	1.94	363	-72	41	6.4×10^{-61}	3.2×10^{-60}	2.9×10^{60}	2.2×10^{-30}

4.2 Survival of the present vacuum: the past light cone

A bubble nucleated at an event p expands at essentially the speed of light and reaches an observer at O if and only if p lies in the causal past of O. If nucleations are Poisson distributed with rate Γ per unit four-volume, the probability that none has occurred in the past light cone of the present observer is [19, 20]

$$P_{\rm surv} = e^{-\Gamma V_4}, \qquad V_4 = \frac{4\pi}{3}\int_0^{t_0} dt\, a(t)^3 \chi(t)^3, \qquad \chi(t) = \int_t^{t_0} \frac{dt'}{a(t')} \tag{9}$$

with χ the comoving distance of the light cone at time t in a flat universe. A common order-of-magnitude shortcut uses the Euclidean volume of the de Sitter four-sphere, $8\pi^2/(3H^4)$; that is not the four-volume of any region of the observed spacetime, and it overstates V_4 by the factor given below. The observed history is $H^2 = H_0^2(\Omega_m a^{-3} + \Omega_r a^{-4} + \Omega_\Lambda)$ with $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.6889$, $\Omega_r = 9.14\times10^{-5}$ (from $T_{\rm CMB}$ and $N_{\rm eff} = 3.046$) and $\Omega_m = 0.3110$. Two independent quadratures give $V_4 = 0.12457\, H_0^{-4} = 0.0591\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, agreeing to 1×10^{-13}; the result is converged in the lower cutoff of the scale factor and in the grid to 10^{-11} and reproduces the analytic Einstein–de Sitter value to 2×10^{-13} (check V14). The Euclidean volume is $26.3\, H_\Lambda^{-4}$, 445 times larger. Of V_4, 35% comes from events at redshift below 1, 73% below 2 and 97% below 5 (Fig. 3); the uncertainty from Ω_Λ at the Planck 1σ level is about 3.5%.

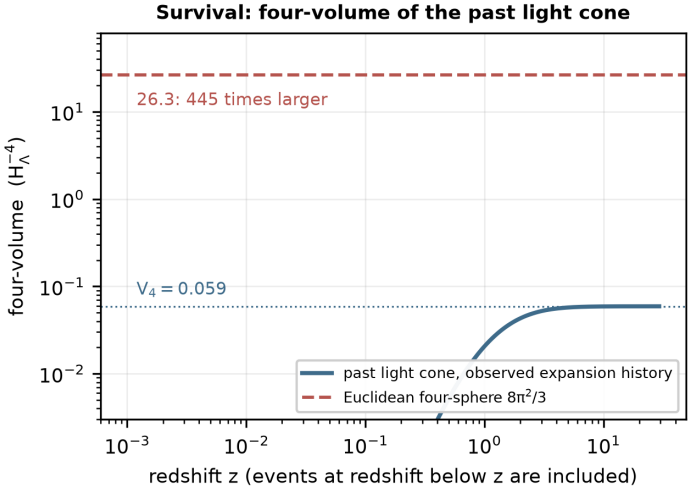


Figure 3: Four-volume of the past light cone of the present observer, accumulated over events at redshift below z, for the observed expansion history, against the Euclidean four-sphere volume.

The observation that no bubble has reached us is excluded at 95% confidence if $\Gamma V_4 > -\ln 0.05 = 3.00$, that is for $\Gamma/H^4 > 50.7$ or $B < B_c - 3.9$. This is a weak condition: it is 1334 times weaker than the Euclidean estimate ($\Gamma/H^4 > 0.038$), it moves the boundary of the allowed region by only $\Delta B = 7.2$ out of about 287, and it bounds the future mean decay time only by $t_{\rm dec} \gtrsim 8.2\times10^7$ yr (the formula for $t_{\rm dec}$ is used here as an order-of-magnitude statement, since Γ/H^4 is not small). Because the prior mass sits overwhelmingly at $B \ll B_c$ or $B \gg B_c$, the fraction of the prior excluded changes from 15.0% (Euclidean estimate) to 14.8% (Section 4.5). The criterion assumes that Γ was constant, with the scalar in its false minimum throughout; it does not require observers to be present before the transition, and it says nothing about bubbles nucleated outside our past cone. Percolation of bubbles in de Sitter space requires a rate of order unity in Hubble units [21, 22], since otherwise the false-vacuum volume grows without bound and no wall collides with another. With the corrected survival bound this no longer conflicts with survival: the window $1 \lesssim \Gamma/H^4 < 51$ has the width $\Delta B = 3.9$ and contains 0.12% of the prior volume (0.18% for a percolation threshold of 0.1 and 0.05% for 10).

4.3 The prefactor and the validity of the semiclassical rate

The factor D is the ratio of the fluctuation determinants with the zero modes removed; methods to compute it for specific potentials exist [17, 18] and are not repeated here. It is treated as a systematic uncertainty. Because $\ln D$ enters B_c additively, a change of D by n decades moves B_c by $2.3\,n$: three decades give ± 7 out of 287, six decades give ± 14 (5%), and the prior mass of every regime changes by less than 10^{-3} over spreads of 0, 3 and 6 decades (Table 5). The semiclassical expansion is controlled by $1/B$, which is 3.5×10^{-3} at B_c, so that higher-loop corrections change $\ln\Gamma$ by $O(1)$ and not $O(B)$, which the prefactor spread already covers. The regime in which the approximation fails is $B = O(1)$ to $O(10)$, where the wall is not thin on the scale of the field fluctuations; 0.5% of the prior has $B < 10$ and 2.5% has $B < 30$, and none of these draws survives the survival condition (all have $\Gamma/H^4 \gg 51$), so the failure of the semiclassical approximation affects only the excluded region and cannot change the classification of any draw that is allowed.

4.4 The falsification diagram

Fig. 4 maps the decay time over the (η, λ) plane for $r_L = 1$. The region excluded by survival and the region of effective stability ($t_{\rm dec} > 10^{100}$ yr) are separated by a band: the decay time runs from the survival bound of 8.2×10^7 yr to 10^{20} yr within a change of $\Delta B \simeq 28$ in the action and to 10^{100} yr within $\Delta B \simeq 212$. The model is thus either excluded, or it describes a vacuum that decays on a time scale of 10^{20} yr or longer unless B is tuned to within about 28 of the survival bound, that is within 10% of its value.

4.5 Prior-sensitivity Monte Carlo

To quantify how much of the parameter space the window occupies, $1,000,000$ parameter sets are drawn from physically consistent priors ($\log_{10}\lambda$ uniform on $[-2, \log_{10} 4\pi]$, η uniform on $[0.03, 0.38]$, $\ln D$ Gaussian with a spread of 1.5 decades; the false minimum exists for every draw) and each is converted to a rate with the interpolated numerical action. The regime fractions are given in Table 5 together with batch-means standard errors (20 batches), convergence with the number of draws (Fig. 5c) and sensitivity to the priors. 14.8% of the prior volume lies above the survival bound, 0.77% decays within 10^{20} yr, 4.8% within 10^{100} yr and 80.4% shows no decay within 10^{100} yr. The fractions do not depend on the prefactor and the choice of r_L is likewise immaterial. They do depend on the prior range of λ and η (Table 5; for $\lambda \leq 1$ the excluded fraction falls to 2.8%). They are therefore fractions of the stated prior, a property of the parameter space of this model and not measured probabilities, and they do not indicate how likely a transition is in our universe. $V_t < 0$ would enter through $r_L = 1/(1 + |V_t|/V_f) < 1$ and shifts B_c upward by $\ln(1 + |V_t|/V_f)$; the case $r_L \geq 1$ is the one sampled.

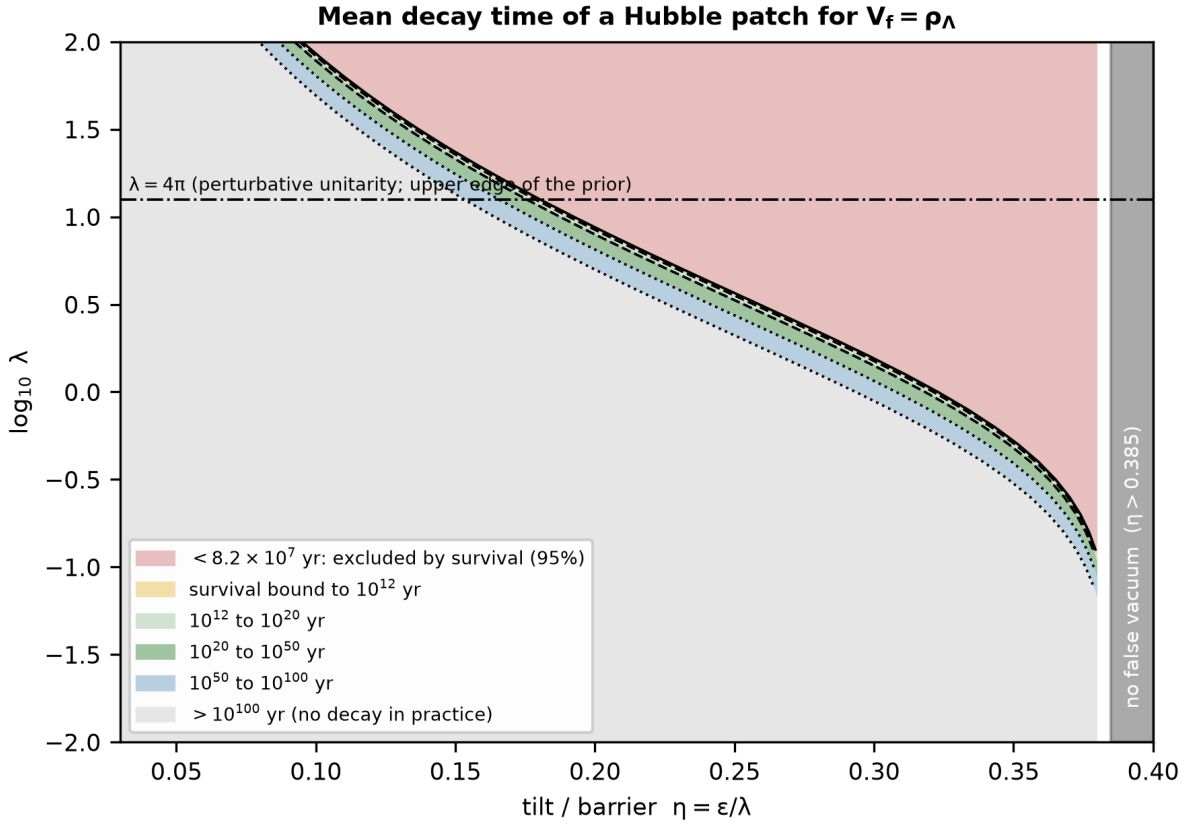


Figure 4: Mean decay time of a Hubble patch in the (η, λ) plane for $V_f = \rho_\Lambda$ and a Minkowski true vacuum. Contours: survival bound (8.2×10^7 yr), 10^{12}, 10^{20}, 10^{50} and 10^{100} yr. The upper edge $\lambda = 4\pi$ is the perturbative-unitarity limit used for the prior.

Table 5: Prior mass (%) of each regime. Decay fractions are cumulative and refer to survival-consistent draws; the last column is the fraction with no decay within 10^{100} yr. These are fractions of the stated prior, not probabilities for our universe.

Prior	above survival bound	decays by 10^{12} yr	by 10^{20} yr	by 10^{100} yr	no decay in 10^{100} yr
baseline	14.77 ± 0.04	0.269 ± 0.005	0.77 ± 0.01	4.78 ± 0.02	80.4 ± 0.0
$\sigma_{\log D} = 0$	14.74	0.270	0.76	4.80	80.5
$\sigma_{\log D} = 3$	14.75	0.257	0.75	4.79	80.5
$\sigma_{\log D} = 6$	14.74	0.267	0.76	4.79	80.5
r_L logU(1, 10)	14.71	0.264	0.76	4.80	80.5
$\lambda \leq 1$	2.76	0.122	0.35	2.50	94.7
η in [0.10, 0.38]	18.45	0.323	0.95	5.96	75.6
log10 λ in [-4, 2]	18.18	0.190	0.55	3.35	78.5

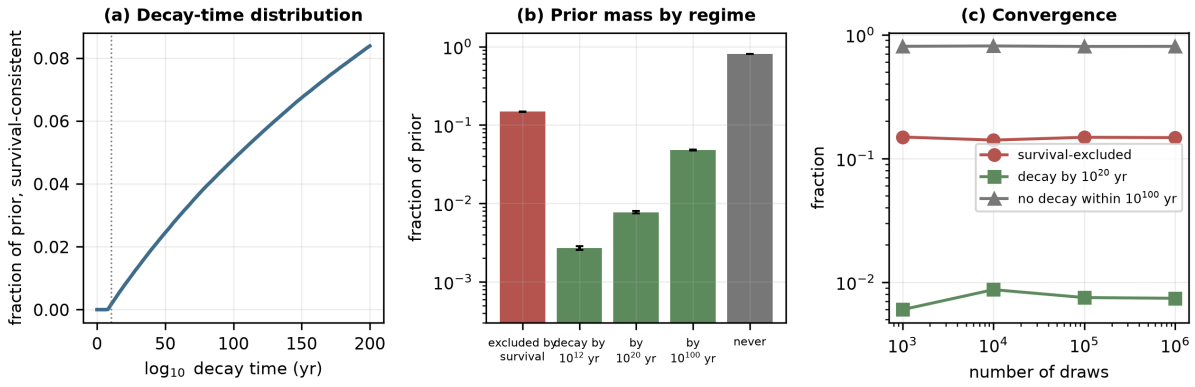


Figure 5: (a) Cumulative distribution of the decay time over survival-consistent draws. (b) Prior mass by regime with 3σ batch errors. (c) Convergence of the regime fractions with the number of draws.

4.6 Cooling and the thermally corrected potential

The calculation above treats the universe as a clock: the CMB temperature $T_\gamma = T_0/a$ falls with the expansion and enters nothing. It can enter the decay only if the scalar interacts with a thermal bath, and then through a thermal correction to the potential whose coefficient c is fixed by those interactions and is not a universal constant. Two regimes are therefore kept apart throughout: the scalar is decoupled and the decay is the zero-temperature O(4) channel of the previous sections, or it is in thermal equilibrium with the CMB, in which case the leading high-temperature term is

$$V_{\rm eff}(\varphi, T) = V_0(\varphi) + \tfrac{1}{2}\, c T^2 \varphi^2, \qquad \theta \equiv \frac{c T^2}{\lambda f^2} \tag{10}$$

The thermal term is a rescaling of the zero-temperature family, which makes the analysis exact. With $x = sy$ and $s = \sqrt{1-2\theta}$ the potential $(x^2-1)^2/8 + \eta x/2 + \theta x^2/2$ becomes $s^4[(y^2-1)^2/8 + (\eta/s^3)y/2]$ up to a constant. Hence a false minimum exists only for

$$\eta_{\rm eff} \equiv \frac{\eta}{(1-2\theta)^{3/2}} < \eta_c \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \theta < \theta_c(\eta) = \frac{1}{2}\left[1 - \left(\frac{\eta}{\eta_c}\right)^{2/3}\right] \tag{11}$$

and the bounce actions are those of the zero-temperature table at the shifted tilt: $B_4 = b(\eta_{\rm eff})/\lambda$ and $S_3 = (fs/\sqrt{\lambda})\, s_3(\eta_{\rm eff})$, where $s_3 = 4\pi \int \rho^2 [x'^2/2 + w - w_f] d\rho$ is the O(3) action at $\lambda = 1$, $\theta = 0$ (tabulated here for the first time for this family, with the boundary-value solver for $\eta < 0.1$, and tending to the thin-wall value $16\pi\sigma^3/3\Delta V^2$ as $\eta \to 0$: the ratio is 0.995 at $\eta = 0.03$). Direct solutions of the O(4) and O(3) bounce with the thermal term in the potential agree with these scalings to 2×10^{-4} (check V19). For the benchmark $\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$: $f = 3.05$ meV, $\theta_c = 0.0765$, and today ($T_0 = 0.235$ meV) $\theta = 0.0059\, c$.

Cooling relaxes the thermal term, and the thermal history has a consequence that does not depend on the decay rate: the false minimum disappears at $T_c = f\sqrt{\lambda\theta_c/c}$, which is 2.7 meV (redshift 10) for $c = 0.1$ and 0.84 meV (redshift 2.6) for $c = 1$. A scalar in equilibrium with the CMB at higher temperatures would have settled into the true vacuum at the symmetric-

to-broken transition, and the present dark energy would not be the false-vacuum energy. The observed universe in the false vacuum therefore requires that the scalar either decoupled before T_c or has $c < 1.1 \times 10^{-5}$ if the bath is coupled all the way back to recombination ($z = 1100$). The high-temperature form is an upper bound on the effect for particles heavier than T in the loop, since the true correction is then Boltzmann suppressed; the results below are therefore the largest thermal effect that the coefficient c can produce.

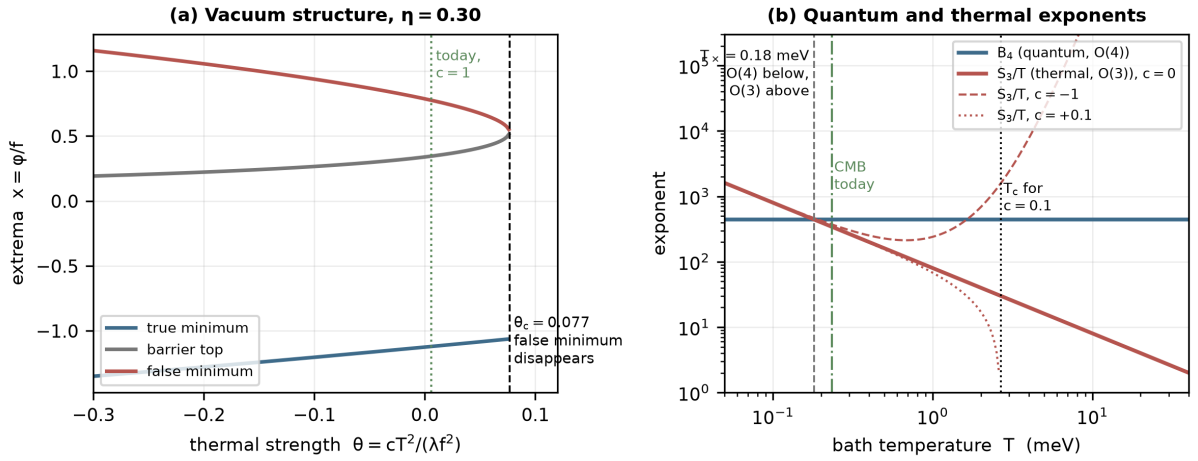


Figure 6: (a) Extrema of the thermally corrected potential for $\eta = 0.30$ against the thermal strength θ; the false minimum disappears at θ_c. (b) The quantum exponent B_4 and the thermal exponent S_3/T against the bath temperature for the benchmark; the O(3) saddle dominates above the crossover temperature $T_\times$ (where $S_3/T = B_4$) and the O(4) saddle below. Solid: $c = 0$ (equilibrium without thermal mass); dashed: $c = -1$; dotted: $c = +0.1$.

4.7 The cooling history and the three decay channels

The temperature follows the observed history, $T_\gamma(a) = T_0/a$ with $H(a)$ of Section 4.2, and cosmic time $t(a) - t_0 = \int_1^a da'/[a'H(a')]$. Three channels compete. The Hawking–Moss transition is the horizon-scale channel of de Sitter space; its action is $\ln B_{\rm HM} \simeq 279$ (Section 3.4) and it plays no role. The de Sitter horizon temperature $T_{\rm dS} = H_\Lambda/2\pi = 1.91 \times 10^{-31}$ meV is 8.1×10^{-31} of T_0, would equal the CMB temperature only after 69 e-folds ($\sim 10^{12}$ yr), and is not a homogeneous radiation bath; it is therefore kept separate and not combined with T_γ by a maximum. The thermal exponent at the horizon temperature, $S_3/T_{\rm dS} = 4.2 \times 10^{32}$, rules out any activation by it. That leaves quantum tunneling (the O(4) bounce with action B_4) and thermal activation (the O(3) bounce with S_3/T). At a given temperature the saddle with the smaller exponent dominates, and the rate takes its exponent and prefactor; the two rates are not added, because they are the two ends of one family of periodic instantons. The thermal prefactor is $\Gamma_T = D_T\, T^4 (S_3/2\pi T)^{3/2} e^{-S_3/T}$ with D_T of order unity (a systematic of 1.5 decades, as for the quantum prefactor).

For the benchmark the crossover is at $T_\times = 0.181$ meV, so that today the thermal saddle already dominates ($S_3/T_0 = 341 < B_4 = 441$), the crossover being reached when the CMB has cooled by a factor 1.29, and in the past the thermal exponent was far smaller (Table 6, Fig. 6b). Cooling lowers the rate for $c \geq 0$ at every epoch: the thermal exponent grows as $1/T$ and the thermal

mass relaxes, so $\ln\Gamma$ falls monotonically with time (check V20). The late-time decay is therefore the zero-temperature O(4) decay of Section 4, because the thermal contribution switches off exponentially fast as $T \propto e^{-H_\Lambda t}$. For $c < 0$ (symmetry non-restoration, outside the usual sign of the thermal mass) the barrier grows with T and cooling lowers B_4, so the sign of the effect is reversed for the quantum channel, but the thermal exponent still has a minimum near $z \simeq 2$ for $c = -1$ and the past rate is not small.

Table 6: Exponents and rates for the benchmark ($\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$) as the universe cools. B_4 and S_3/T at $c = 0$; $\ln\Gamma/H_\Lambda^4$ for the decoupled scalar (O(4) only) and for the equilibrated scalar with the dominant saddle in brackets.

z	T (meV)	B_4	S_3/T	decoupled	$c = 0$	$c = 0.1$	$c = -1$
0	0.235	441	341	-153	-65 (O(3))	-62 (O(3))	-95 (O(3))
0.5	0.352	441	227	-153	50 (O(3))	54 (O(3))	4 (O(3))
1	0.470	441	170	-153	107 (O(3))	113 (O(3))	46 (O(3))
2	0.705	441	114	-153	165 (O(3))	173 (O(3))	66 (O(3))
3	0.939	441	85	-153	194 (O(3))	205 (O(3))	49 (O(3))

4.8 Survival with a time-dependent rate and the thermal prior maps

With a rate that depends on the temperature, the expected number of nucleations in the past light cone is

$$I = \frac{4\pi}{3}\int_{t_i}^{t_0} dt\,\Gamma(T_\gamma(t))\,a(t)^3\chi(t)^3, \qquad P_{\rm surv} = e^{-I} \tag{12}$$

with χ as in Eq. (9). It assumes a flat universe and a homogeneous rate per physical four-volume, and walls at the speed of light. For a constant rate it reduces to Eq. (9), reproduced by the quadrature to 7×10^{-9}. For the benchmark, $\ln I = -155$ for the decoupled scalar (the vacuum survives), while an equilibrated scalar gives $\ln I = 99$ ($c = 0$, bath coupled for $z \le 1$), 186 ($z \le 3$) and 240 ($z \le 10$): the benchmark is excluded by many orders of magnitude as soon as it is in equilibrium with the CMB. The same calculation over the priors of Section 4.5 (2×10^5 draws, the same seed, plus a thermal prefactor spread of 1.5 decades) gives Table 7 and Fig. 7.

Table 7: Prior mass (%) by thermal scenario (2×10^5 draws; z is the redshift below which the scalar is in equilibrium with the CMB). "Inconsistent" draws have no false minimum at some redshift of the equilibrium epoch. Decay fractions refer to the allowed draws and to the zero-temperature decay of the future.

Scenario	above survival bound	no false minimum in the past	allowed	decays by 10^{20} yr	no decay in
decoupled	14.7	0.0	85.3	0.79	80.5
$c = 0$, $z \le 1$	24.2	0.0	75.8	0.00	75.8
$c = 0$, $z \le 3$	33.9	0.0	66.1	0.00	66.1
$c = 0$, $z \le 10$	49.3	0.0	50.7	0.00	50.7
$c = 0.1$, $z \le 1$	24.9	1.3	73.8	0.00	73.8
$c = 0.1$, $z \le 3$	33.6	7.4	59.0	0.00	59.0
$c = 1$, $z \le 1$	23.2	17.6	59.2	0.00	59.2
$c = -0.1$, $z \le 1100$	38.0	0.0	62.0	0.00	62.0
$c = -1$, $z \le 1100$	23.8	0.0	76.2	0.17	75.4

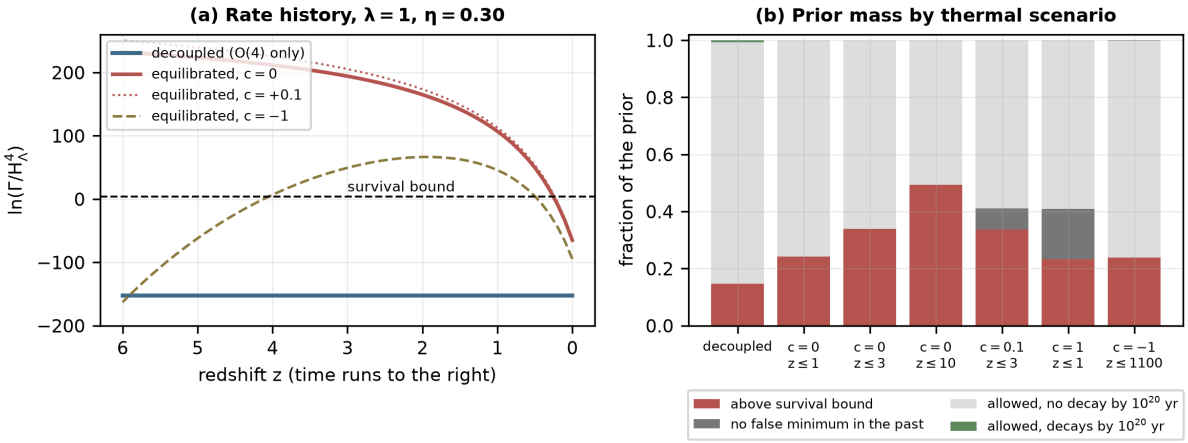


Figure 7: (a) Rate history of the benchmark: the decoupled O(4) rate is constant, the equilibrated rate falls as the universe cools; the dashed line is the survival bound on Γ/H_Λ^4. (b) Prior mass by thermal scenario.

The results answer the question posed by cooling. First, a scalar that is not coupled to the CMB is unaffected; the decay of the previous sections stands. Second, a scalar in equilibrium with the CMB is constrained more strongly, not less: the prior mass above the survival bound rises from 14.7% to 24% ($z \leq 1$), 34% ($z \leq 3$) and 49% ($z \leq 10$) for $c = 0$, and a further 1.3% to 18% of the draws have no false minimum in the equilibrium epoch for $c = 0.1$ and 1. Third, in no equilibrated scenario with $c \geq 0$ does a survival-consistent draw decay within 10^{20} yr: the decay window of Section 4.4 closes completely. The reason is that the allowed draws must have a thermal exponent large enough at $z \sim 1$, and because $S_3/T < B_4$ above $T_\times$ this requires B_4 well above the critical action, so that the zero-temperature decay time of the future exceeds 10^{100} yr. Fourth, only the non-standard sign $c = -1$ leaves a window (0.17% of the prior against 0.79% for the decoupled scalar). In short, cooling cannot raise the probability of a late-time transition: it lowers the thermal channel monotonically, the late-time decay is the zero-temperature O(4) decay, and the thermal coupling only adds past constraints.

5 What the nucleated region can become

5.1 Energy budget

A thin-wall bubble of true vacuum is bounded by a wall that carries the released energy; its interior is, to leading order, the true vacuum with no excess energy to reheat. In the thick-wall regime relevant here the field at the centre of the bounce, x_0, lies above the true minimum, and the energy the interior can release is $\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V = V(x_0) - V_t$. Fig. 8c shows $\epsilon_{\rm in}$ against η: at $\eta = 0.30$, $\epsilon_{\rm in} = 0.018$, so 1.8% of ΔV resides in the interior and the remainder in the wall; $\epsilon_{\rm in}$ approaches unity only near η_c, where the barrier is gone.

5.2 Interior geometry and reheating

The interior of a CDL bubble has open spatial slices, $ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 dH_3^2$ [23, 24], with the Friedmann constraint $(da/dt)^2 = 1 + a^2\rho/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$. Without a long inflationary stage inside the bubble (Section 5.3), the energy density is negligible against the curvature term at early times: $\alpha^2\rho \leq 1.1 \times 10^{-61}$ in units where $H_\Lambda = 1$, so the interior is a Milne universe, $a = t$. The condensate begins to oscillate at $t_0 = 1/m$ with $m = 3.61$ meV, behaves as matter and decays to radiation at a rate $\Gamma_\varphi \leq m$. With $\tau = H_\Lambda t$ the radiation density has the closed form $\rho_r(\tau) = \epsilon\,\tau_0^3\,\gamma\,\tau^{-4}\int_{\tau_0}^{\tau} s\,e^{-\gamma(s-\tau_0)}ds$ in units of V_f, which we compare with a numerical integration of the full system (relative difference 6×10^{-7}). The radiation temperature is $T = (30\rho_r/\pi^2 g_*)^{1/4}$ with $g_* = 3.36$.

Energy conservation bounds the reheating temperature independently of the details of the decay,

$$T_{\rm reh} \leq \left[\frac{30\,\epsilon_{\rm th}\,\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V}{\pi^2 g_*}\right]^{1/4}, \qquad \epsilon_{\rm th} \leq 1 \tag{13}$$

which for the largest release allowed when $V_t \geq 0$, $\epsilon_{\rm in}\Delta V = \Delta V \leq V_f = \rho_\Lambda$, gives $T_{\rm reh} \leq 2.19$ meV (25 K), against the CMB temperature of 0.235 meV today and 4.6×10^8 times below the ~ 1 MeV required for nucleosynthesis [42]. Equivalently, a thermal bath at 1 MeV needs an energy density 1.4×10^{35} times the dark-energy density. The closed form shows that the situation is worse than the bound: the radiation temperature after its maximum falls as $T \propto 1/\tau$ because the open interior keeps expanding, with $T\tau = 5.46 \times 10^{-43}$ GeV, so $T = 1$ MeV would have to occur at $t = 3.0 \times 10^{-22}$ s, before the condensate even starts to oscillate ($t_0 = 1.8 \times 10^{-13}$ s). Table 8 gives the maximum temperature for decay rates from $\Gamma_\varphi = m$ down to $10^{-20}m$ and the temperature one Hubble time after nucleation, $\sim 10^{-30}$ meV.

Table 8: Reheating of the bubble interior. ϵ: fraction of ΔV in the interior; Γ_φ/m: decay rate of the oscillating condensate; $T_{\rm max}$: maximum radiation temperature; the fourth column is $T_{\rm max}$ over the bound of Eq. (13); the fifth is the temperature one Hubble time $1/H_\Lambda$ after nucleation; the last is $T_{\rm BBN}/T_{\rm max}$.

ϵ	Γ_φ/m	$T_{\rm max}$ (meV)	$T_{\rm max}/T_{\rm bound}$	$T(1/H_\Lambda)$ (meV)	$T_{\rm BBN}/T_{\rm max}$
1 (upper bound)	1	1.2445	0.57	8.7×10^{-31}	8.0×10^{8}
1 (upper bound)	0.001	0.2318	0.11	4.1×10^{-30}	4.3×10^{9}
1 (upper bound)	1e-09	0.0073	0.00	1.3×10^{-28}	1.4×10^{11}
1 (upper bound)	1e-20	0.0000	0.00	7.3×10^{-26}	7.7×10^{13}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1	0.4558	0.57	3.2×10^{-31}	2.2×10^{9}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	0.001	0.0849	0.11	1.5×10^{-30}	1.2×10^{10}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1e-09	0.0027	0.00	4.7×10^{-29}	3.7×10^{11}
0.018 ($\eta = 0.30$)	1e-20	0.0000	0.00	2.7×10^{-26}	2.1×10^{14}

5.3 Scope of the bound: what is excluded by the model and what only by energy conservation

The bound of Eq. (13) is a statement about a locally homogeneous conversion of a vacuum-energy difference that does not exceed the dark-energy density. It is not a universal prohibition

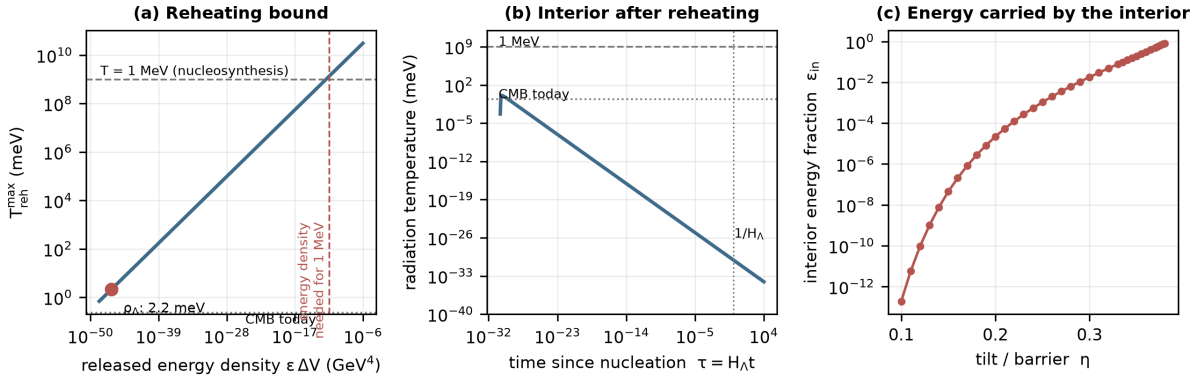


Figure 8: (a) Maximum reheating temperature against the released energy density; the dark-energy density gives about 2 meV, far below the energy density needed for 1 MeV. (b) Temperature of the open interior after reheating ($\Gamma_\varphi = m$): the radiation cools as $1/t$ and never approaches nucleosynthesis. (c) Fraction of ΔV carried by the interior against the tilt.

on high-temperature bubble interiors, and it is stated here with its assumptions: (A1) one real scalar field minimally coupled to gravity, with the potential of Section 2; (A2) the false-vacuum energy is the observed dark energy; (A3) the interior is homogeneous and isotropic on open slices; (A4) no inflationary stage inside the bubble; (A5) all energy densities are sub-Planckian. Models that violate one of these need a separate analysis. Table 9 lists the possible additional energy sources and says which of them the model excludes by more than energy conservation.

The geometric argument is the following. In the open slicing the curvature parameter $Y \equiv a^2\rho/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$ obeys $(da/dt)^2 = 1 + Y$. A hot big bang at nucleosynthesis needs $Y \sim 1$: in standard radiation domination $Ht = 1/2$, that is $\rho t^2 = 3M_{\rm Pl}^2/4$. In the curvature-dominated phase $a = t$ and $Y = \rho t^2/(3M_{\rm Pl}^2)$ can only decrease, as $1/t$ for matter and $1/t^2$ for radiation, unless the interior inflates. The energy density of the condensate and its decay products obeys the envelope

$$\rho(t) \le \epsilon\,\Delta V\,(mt)^{-3} \quad (t > t_0 = 1/m), \qquad Y(t_0) = \frac{\epsilon\,\Delta V}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2 m^2} \tag{14}$$

because matter dilutes more slowly than radiation and decay only moves energy from the slower to the faster component (checked against the closed form to machine precision, check V17). The mass at the true minimum is $m = \kappa_m \Delta V^{1/4}$ with $\kappa_m = \lambda^{1/4}[(3x_t^2 - 1)/2]^{1/2}\delta^{-1/4}$, which lies between 0.50 and 4.1 over the whole prior, so $Y(t_0) = c\sqrt{\Delta V}/M_{\rm Pl}^2$ is tiny for any sub-Planckian energy: $Y(t_0) = 2.0 \times 10^{-63}$ at $\Delta V = V_f$, and $Y(t_0) = 1$ would need $\Delta V/M_{\rm Pl}^4 = 1.8 \times 10^5$ at the benchmark, which is super-Planckian. Therefore, for any ΔV below the Planck scale, the interior is a Milne universe at all times, Y never approaches unity (Fig. 9), and the energy density at one second after nucleation cannot exceed $\epsilon\Delta V/(m \cdot 1\,\mathrm{s})^3$. Requiring $\rho(1\ \mathrm{s}) \ge \rho_{\rm BBN} = (\pi^2 g_*/30)(1\ \mathrm{MeV})^4$ ($g_* = 10.75$) demands $\Delta V^{1/4} \ge 5.1 \times 10^{61}$ GeV, that is 42, 43 and 45 orders of magnitude above the Planck mass (for the smallest κ_m in the prior, the benchmark and the largest). For the dark energy the envelope gives $\rho(1\ \mathrm{s}) = 4.4 \times 10^{-74}\,\rho_{\rm BBN}$.

Three points follow. First, the anti-de Sitter case shows that energy conservation alone is not sufficient: a very deep true vacuum releases enough energy for 1 MeV, but its open interior then

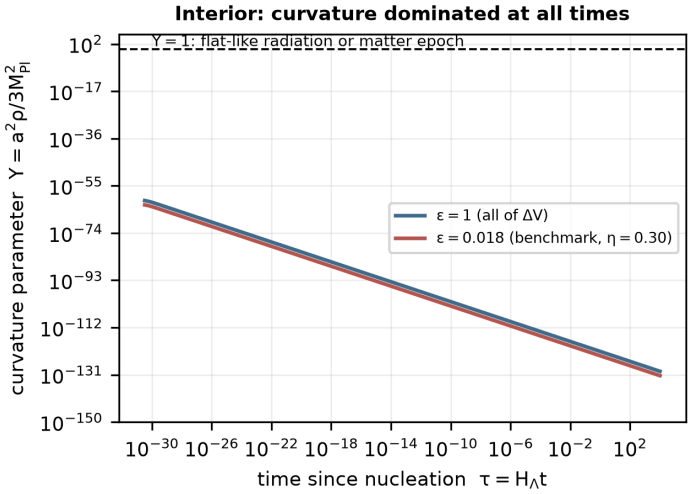


Figure 9: Curvature parameter $Y = a^2\rho/3M_{\rm Pl}^2$ of the bubble interior against the time since nucleation for $\Gamma_\varphi = m$. A flat-like radiation- or matter-dominated epoch needs $Y \sim 1$; the interior starts at $Y \sim 10^{-63}$ and moves away from it.

Table 9: Energy sources and assumptions behind the reheating bound, and what excludes each.

Source or assumption	What bounds it	Quantitative statement
Released vacuum energy, $V_t \geq 0$	energy conservation, $\Delta V \leq V_f$	$T_{\rm reh} \leq 2.19$ meV
Wall energy $(1-\epsilon_{\rm in})\Delta V$	already counted in ΔV; collisions redistribute it	benchmark: 98% of ΔV in the wall; the total is unchanged
Deeper true vacuum, $V_t < 0$ (anti-de Sitter)	geometry: crunch at $t_c = \pi\sqrt{3}M_{\rm Pl}/\sqrt{\lvert V_t\rvert}$ and the curvature envelope	$T_{\rm max} = 1$ MeV needs $\lvert V_t\rvert = 1.4\times10^{35}\,V_f$ and a crunch after 4.6 s; a life of 13.8 Gyr needs $\lvert V_t\rvert \leq 15.7\,V_f$ and $T \leq 4.4$ meV
Interior inflation	the potential has no plateau above V_f; field range $\Delta\varphi/M_{\rm Pl} \sim 10^{-30}$	at most 9.3×10^{-62} e-folds (largest over four tilts)
Larger parent scale ($V_f \gg \rho_\Lambda$)	geometry: the envelope $\rho \leq \epsilon\Delta V(mt)^{-3}$	$\rho(1\text{ s}) \geq \rho_{\rm BBN}$ needs $\Delta V^{1/4}$ 42 to 45 orders above $M_{\rm Pl}$
Extra reservoir (other fields, radiation)	not part of the model; subject to the same curvature constraint	$Y \sim 1$ at $t = 1/m$ needs $\rho_x = 9.1\times10^{60}\,\Delta V$
Inhomogeneity, bubble collisions	not included (A3); total energy is bounded by ΔV	local concentration possible; the average is unchanged

collapses within seconds, and the longest-lived interior has $T \lesssim 4$ meV. Second, the geometric statement is independent of the energy scale and of the value of V_f, and therefore covers an additional reservoir too: it cannot raise Y above the curvature bound unless its energy density exceeds ΔV by 9.1×10^{60}. Third, the escape routes are exactly those the model lacks: a long inflationary stage inside the bubble, a parent energy scale close to the Planck scale, or an additional mechanism that raises Y at t_0. A successful cosmology would have to lie in that outside class.

A second scalar field χ does not change this. For any number of scalar fields with a potential $V(\varphi, \chi)$, the energy released in the transition of a homogeneous region is the potential difference between the false and true vacua, $V_f - V_t$, and the false-vacuum energy $V_f = V(\varphi_f, \chi_f)$ is the whole observed dark energy ρ_Λ: any energy stored in χ while it sits in the false vacuum gravitates as dark energy and is already counted in V_f. A larger release needs $V_t < 0$ (the anti-de Sitter row of Table 9, a crunch within seconds), and the curvature argument above is independent of the field content. A reservoir that is not vacuum energy (radiation, matter, kinetic energy of χ) would have been present and gravitating throughout the cold era, where observations limit it to a fraction of the critical density, whereas the interior needs $\rho_x = 9.1 \times 10^{60}\, \Delta V$. A coupled two-field model is therefore a relabelling of ΔV and not a source of new energy, unless the second sector inflates or carries a Planck-scale parent energy, which is the outside class of Section 7. The simulations of Section 5.5 confirm it.

5.4 Other fates and the singularity question

If the true vacuum has negative energy ($V_t < 0$) the open interior collapses to a singularity in a finite time, $\tau_c = \pi/\sqrt{|V_t|/V_f}$: $|V_t| = 0.01\, V_f$: 547 Gyr; $|V_t| = 0.1\, V_f$: 173 Gyr; $|V_t| = 1\, V_f$: 55 Gyr; $|V_t| = 10\, V_f$: 17 Gyr. A decay to a de Sitter vacuum with $V_t > 0$ leaves the interior with an accelerating phase and no radiation epoch. Only $V_t \simeq 0$ leaves a regular, expanding, but empty interior. No case yields a nonsingular bounce from the parent geometry: the bubble is a region of the parent de Sitter space, causally connected to it, and the Milne interior is geodesically complete only because it has no matter.

The distinction between daughter regions and a cyclic cosmology (Section 1) applies to these fates. The nucleated region is a daughter region in the sense of Option A: a cold, curvature-dominated open region bounded by the wall inside the parent de Sitter space and still causally connected to it, not a new hot universe. The potential has no further metastable minimum at the true vacuum, so repeated transitions of the interior would need a different potential; the entropy produced in reheating is bounded by the energy ΔV and is carried by an open interior of infinite comoving volume, so no entropy statement can be made for the daughter as a closed system. A cyclic cosmology (Option B) needs a nonsingular bounce, which in spatially flat general relativity with conventional matter requires a violation of the null energy condition ($\dot{H} = -(\rho + p)/2M_{\rm Pl}^2 > 0$) and raises problems of stability and entropy [9, 10]; the present model contains no such mechanism, and Section 5.6 adds an effective one to test the cycles that would follow. Entropy accounting and causality are computed for the daughter region in Section 5.5; the stability of an interior bounce is not.

5.5 Lorentzian simulations of the daughter region: two fields, reservoirs and repeated transitions

The interior was also simulated, not only bounded. The analytic continuation of the bounce gives the open homogeneous interior with the field starting at the bounce centre x_0 at rest and $a = t$ (Milne). In units of f for the fields and λf^4 for energy densities, with $g = f^2/M_{\rm Pl}^2$, the system is

$$\ddot{x}_i + \left(3\frac{\dot{a}}{a} + \Upsilon_i\right)\dot{x}_i + \frac{\partial V}{\partial x_i} = 0, \qquad \dot{\rho}_r + 4\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\rho_r = \sum_i \Upsilon_i \dot{x}_i^2, \qquad \ddot{a} = -\frac{g\,a}{6}(\rho + 3p) \tag{15}$$

with $\rho = \frac{1}{2}\sum_i \dot{x}_i^2 + V + \rho_r$, $p = \frac{1}{2}\sum_i \dot{x}_i^2 - V + \rho_r/3$ and the constraint $\dot{a}^2 = 1 + g\,a^2\rho/3$, whose relative residual is the energy-conservation check (eighth-order Runge–Kutta, relative tolerance 10^{-11}). The friction Υ_i is a phenomenological dissipation that moves field energy to radiation with total energy conserved. The simulations are the following (check V22–V24 and Table 10–13).

(A) Single field, physical benchmark ($\lambda = 1$, $\eta = 0.30$, $f = 3.05$ meV, $g = 1.6 \times 10^{-60}$). The full dynamics give a maximum radiation temperature within 7% of the closed form of Section 5.2 for Γ_φ/m from 1 to 10^{-3} (ratios 0.93, 1.04, 1.06 and 1.06), so the assumption that the condensate starts to oscillate at $1/m$ and dilutes as matter is sound. The constraint residual is at most 9×10^{-9} for $g \geq 10^{-3}$ (it scales with g and is trivially small at $g = 10^{-60}$, so the gravitational scan below is the real test). Scanning g from 10^{-60} to 10^3, the curvature parameter $Y = ga^2\rho/3$ reaches 3.9×10^{-2} at $g = 10^1$ and 0.48 at $g = 10^2$; a flat-like radiation epoch ($Y \geq 1/4$ with radiation dominant) first appears at $g = 10^2$, that is $f = 10\,M_{\rm Pl}$. For the dark-energy scale $g = 10^{-60}$ and $Y_{\max} = 3.9 \times 10^{-63}$.

(B) Two fields with an energy reservoir. A second field χ (here $V_\chi = \frac{\lambda_\chi}{4}(\chi^2 - w_\chi^2)^2$ with $\lambda_\chi = 1$, $w_\chi = 1.5f$, coupled by $\frac{1}{2}g_c^2(\varphi - \varphi_t)^2\chi^2$ so that it is stable in the false vacuum and tachyonic in the true one) stores 1.27 λf^4, 4.3 times the energy ΔV released by φ. A constant offset $V_{\rm off} = -(\Delta V + E_\chi)$ makes the false vacuum have the observed dark-energy density, which is the only way the reservoir can sit in the parent without gravitating. The true vacuum is then anti-de Sitter with $|V_t| = \Delta V + E_\chi$, and the simulation (dissipation $\Upsilon = m/2$ in both fields, χ seeded at $10^{-6}f$) transfers the reservoir to radiation. The depth is set in units of the dark energy, $|V_t| = \kappa\rho_\Lambda$, which fixes f and g (Table 10). For $\kappa = 10^{35}$ (enough for 1 MeV) the radiation reaches 0.72 MeV after 8.9×10^{-21} s, and the interior crunches after 5.46 s, equal to the pure anti-de Sitter value $\pi\sqrt{3}M_{\rm Pl}/\sqrt{|V_t|}$ to better than 10^{-12}. The temperature then falls as $1/t$, with $Tt = 10.9$ for this reservoir (between 10.7 and 13.5 for reservoirs from 0.02 to 20 in units of λf^4), so that at one second $T = 7.6 \times 10^{-24}$ GeV for every depth, 1×10^{20} times below 1 MeV. The envelope of Section 5.3 holds with $\rho(mt)^3/E_{\rm rel} \leq 11$ for the single field and 4.3×10^3 for the reservoir, whose hilltop delays the roll by $\sim 16/m$; with that factor the parent scale needed for 1 MeV at 1 s falls by 3.6 orders of magnitude to still 38 orders above the Planck scale. The reservoir therefore does not make a hot, lasting epoch: it makes a hot instant followed by a crunch.

(C) Flattening at the dark-energy scale. With a field of vev w and $V = \frac{\lambda_c}{4}(\chi^2 - w^2)^2$, $\lambda_c w^4/4 = 3H_\Lambda^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2$ (so that the false-vacuum energy is ρ_Λ) and χ seeded at $10^{-5}w$, hilltop inflation inside

Table 10: Two-field reservoir compensated by a negative offset: the true vacuum has $|V_t| = \kappa\rho_\Lambda$. f: field scale; $T_{\max}$ and its time; crunch time of the interior; temperature one second after nucleation.

κ	f (GeV)	$T_{\max}$ (MeV)	time of $T_{\max}$ (s)	crunch (s)	$T(1\text{ s})$ (GeV)
1×10^{0}	2.0×10^{-12}	1.3×10^{-9}	5.0×10^{-12}	1.7×10^{18}	7.2×10^{-24}
1×10^{10}	6.4×10^{-10}	4.0×10^{-7}	1.6×10^{-14}	1.7×10^{13}	7.2×10^{-24}
1×10^{20}	2.0×10^{-7}	1.3×10^{-4}	5.0×10^{-17}	1.7×10^{8}	7.2×10^{-24}
1×10^{30}	6.4×10^{-5}	4.0×10^{-2}	1.6×10^{-19}	1.7×10^{3}	7.2×10^{-24}
1×10^{35}	1.1×10^{-3}	7.2×10^{-1}	8.9×10^{-21}	5.5×10^{0}	7.6×10^{-24}

the open interior gives the e-folds and curvature of Table 11 (gravity fully included, $g = 1$ in these units, constraint residual at most 5×10^{-9}). Flatness ($N \geq 60$, $\Omega_k \lesssim 10^{-52}$) needs $w \gtrsim 4M_{\rm Pl}$: a super-Planckian vev. The reheating temperature is 0.67–1.45 meV in every case, below the bound of Eq. (13) by construction, since the energy released is ρ_Λ. A hot epoch at 1 MeV needs the same dynamics at a parent energy 1.4×10^{35} times the observed dark energy.

Table 11: Hilltop inflation of a field with vev w inside the open interior at the dark-energy scale ($H_\Lambda = M_{\rm Pl} = 1$): e-folds with $q < -0.1$, flatness $N = -\frac{1}{2}\ln\Omega_{k,\min}$, and the maximum radiation temperature.

$w/M_{\rm Pl}$	λ_c	$N_{\rm accel}$	$N_{\rm flat}$	$\Omega_{k,\min}$	$T_{\max}$ (meV)
1	12.000	8.2	6.8	1.2×10^{-6}	1.45
2	0.750	20.5	18.9	3.6×10^{-17}	1.18
3	0.148	38.1	36.3	3.2×10^{-32}	1.02
4	0.047	61.0	59.0	6.1×10^{-52}	0.91
5	0.019	89.3	87.1	2.2×10^{-76}	0.83
6	9.3×10^{-3}	123.1	120.7	1.4×10^{-105}	0.77
8	2.9×10^{-3}	207.0	204.4	2.8×10^{-178}	0.67

(D) Repeated transitions, entropy and causality. A chain of vacua $(\varphi_f, \chi_f) \to (\varphi_t, \chi_f) \to (\varphi_t, \chi_t)$ with a Minkowski end point releases ΔV_1 and then ΔV_2 out of the parent of energy ρ_Λ. The energy released over all generations telescopes, $\sum_i \Delta V_i = \rho_\Lambda - V_{\rm final} \leq \rho_\Lambda$, so the total radiation, and its temperature $T \leq 2.19$ meV, is the same as for a single transition. Each generation has its own decay time (Table 12, from the rate of Eq. (7) with the parent energy of that generation); the second generation of the daughter has a Hubble rate $\sqrt{\Delta V_2/\rho_\Lambda}$ times that of the parent and decays no sooner than 10^{21} yr in the cases that survive. Repeated transitions are therefore possible in principle, but they add no energy. The entropy per comoving curvature volume produced by the benchmark interior is 0.31 in units of f^{-3} and is constant after reheating; the entropy inside a sphere of the bubble-wall radius at the time of the temperature maximum is 4.9, 2×10^{-63} of the area bound $8\pi^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2 R_b^2 = 2.2 \times 10^{63}$ and 2×10^{-122} of the de Sitter horizon entropy of the parent (3.3×10^{122}), so the generalized second law is satisfied with enormous margin and gives no constraint. The interior is the future light cone of the nucleation event, with infinite comoving volume and a logarithmically divergent conformal time, so it contains no region causally connected to the parent except through the wall.

Table 13 states the conditional criteria for renewal in the sense of Option A. A daughter region is a viable hot universe only if the parent vacuum energy is at least 1.4×10^{35} times the observed

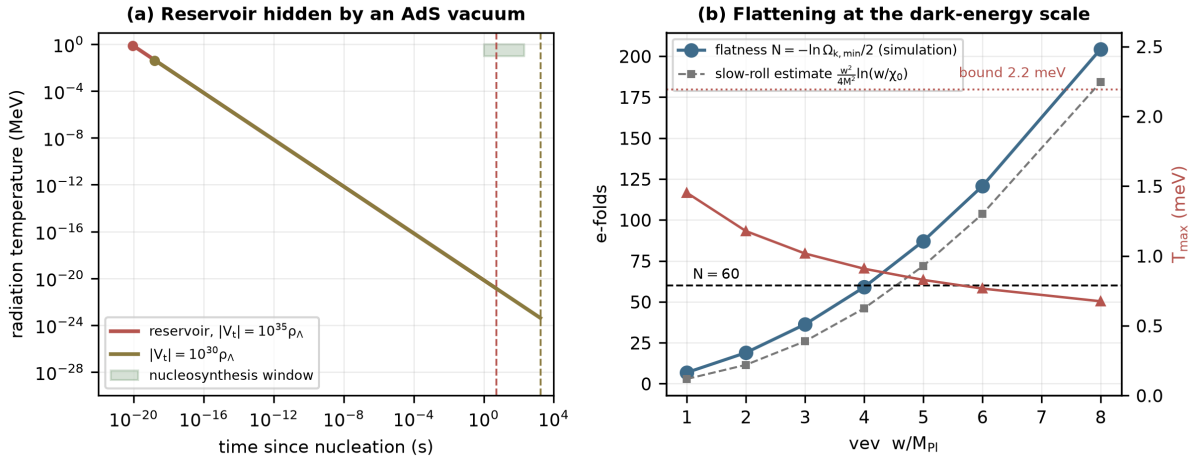


Figure 10: Simulated daughter region. (a) Radiation temperature after nucleation for a reservoir hidden by an anti-de Sitter vacuum of depth $|V_t| = \kappa\rho_\Lambda$ (dots: maximum; dashed: crunch); the green band is the nucleosynthesis window, reached by neither. (b) Hilltop flattening at the dark-energy scale: e-folds against the vev (left) and the maximum temperature (right), with the bound of Eq. (13).

Table 12: Chain of two transitions out of the dark-energy vacuum: tilt/coupling of each step, energy released in units of ρ_Λ, decay time of each generation, total released and the resulting temperature bound.

step 1 (η/λ)	step 2 (η/λ)	$\Delta V_1/\Delta V_2$	$\log_{10} t_1$ (yr)	$\log_{10} t_2$ (yr)	$\sum \Delta V/\rho_\Lambda$	$T_{\max}$ (meV)
0.30 / 1.0	0.30 / 1.0	0.6 / 0.4	76	76	1.00	2.19
0.32 / 1.0	0.28 / 2.0	0.6 / 0.4	16	21	1.00	2.19
0.30 / 1.0	0.33 / 0.5	0.5 / 0.5	76	96	1.00	2.19
0.27 / 3.0	0.27 / 3.0	0.5 / 0.5	-7	-8	1.00	2.19

Table 13: Criteria for a viable daughter universe, by scenario: parent vacuum energy in units of the observed dark energy, maximum temperature, a hot epoch (1 MeV at 1 s), flatness $\Omega_{k,\min}$, lifetime, and the criterion that fails.

Scenario	parent energy/ρ_Λ	$T_{\max}$	hot at 1 s	$\Omega_{k,\min}$	lifetime	fails
Single field, decoupled (benchmark)	1	0.43 meV	no	1 (Milne)	unbounded	none
Reservoir in χ, compensated ($\kappa = 10^{35}$)	1, with a cancellation of 10^{35}	0.72 MeV	no (7.6×10^{-24} GeV at 1 s)	1 (Milne)	5.5 s	crunch
Hilltop at ρ_Λ ($w = 5M_{\rm Pl}$)	1	0.83 meV	no	2×10^{-76}	unbounded	energy
Hilltop at a parent $1.4 \times 10^{35}\,\rho_\Lambda$ ($w = 5M_{\rm Pl}$)	1.4×10^{35} (excluded)	1 MeV	yes	2×10^{-76}	unbounded	survival

one (excluded by the data), or if a reservoir is hidden by a cancellation of the same size, which leaves a true vacuum that crunches within 5.5 s. No scenario with the observed dark energy as the parent satisfies the energy, flatness and lifetime criteria together.

5.6 The same region: turnaround, bounce and repeated cycles (Option B)

A cyclic universe is often pictured as a sinusoid. The quantity that can oscillate is the Hubble rate, not the scale factor, and the prescription

$$H(t) = H_0 \sin \omega t, \qquad a(t) = a_0 \exp\left[-\frac{H_0}{\omega}\cos \omega t\right], \qquad \rho + p = -2M_{\rm Pl}^2 \dot{H} \tag{16}$$

keeps $a > 0$, with a bounce at each zero of H with positive slope and a turnaround at each zero with negative slope. In spatially flat general relativity the last relation shows that the null energy condition is violated whenever $\dot{H} > 0$, that is during exactly half of every period, so a sinusoid cannot be produced by conventional matter and has to be replaced by a dynamical model with a stated bounce mechanism [43, 44], as in ekpyrotic and cyclic constructions [45, 4]. The calculations of this paper supply the turnaround: a decay of the present vacuum into a true vacuum with $V_t < 0$ makes the interior recollapse (Sections 5.3–5.5). For the bounce we use the effective Friedmann equation of loop quantum cosmology [46, 47, 48], an effective model and not established physics,

$$H^2 = \frac{\rho}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(1 - \frac{\rho}{\rho_c}\right) + \frac{1}{a^2}, \qquad \dot{H} = -\frac{\rho + p}{2M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(1 - \frac{2\rho}{\rho_c}\right) - \frac{1}{a^2} \tag{17}$$

for the open interior, with radiation and the scalar oscillating about its anti-de Sitter minimum, $V = V_t + m^2\varphi^2/2$, and an optional dissipation Υ into radiation. The hierarchy $\rho_c/|V_t| \sim 10^{120}$ cannot be integrated directly; the cycles are simulated at $\rho_c/|V_t| = 10^4$ to 10^8 in Planck units, and the scaling of each quantity with $|V_t|$ and ρ_c is measured and extrapolated (oscillation.py; checks V25–V26).

With radiation alone the cycles are exactly periodic: over 21 bounces the period varies by 2×10^{-6} and the turnaround radius returns to 4×10^{-6}. The period is $0.564\,\pi\sqrt{3}M_{\rm Pl}/\sqrt{|V_t|}$, scales as $|V_t|^{-0.500}$ and does not depend on ρ_c (the factor below one is the radiation content; with negligible radiation it tends to one). The bounce is regular: the density reaches ρ_c to 4×10^{-4}, the minimum scale factor stays positive and the curvature scalar remains below $3.5\,\rho_c/M_{\rm Pl}^2$; the constraint residual is at most 3×10^{-5}. The trajectory is far from a sine: H is sharply peaked at the bounce, the fundamental harmonic carries 0.4% of its power, and $\dot{H} > 0$ (an effective violation of the null energy condition) only during 6.4×10^{-4} of each cycle, at the bounce. Repeated expansion and contraction therefore emerge, and the sinusoid does not (Fig. 11a).

The periodic orbit is unstable (Fig. 11b, c). A perturbation of the radiation content only shifts the period, but any oscillation of the scalar is amplified from cycle to cycle: in the linear regime its energy grows by a factor between 6 and 396 per cycle over $m/H_{\rm AdS} = 17$–346 (the field is frozen near the bounce and released with a phase that does not return the energy it gained). Once it is no longer small, successive cycles grow, the cosmological hysteresis of oscillating

models [49]: the turnaround radius rises from 3000 to 2×10^{50} in 15 cycles. Dissipation into radiation competes with the amplification: the cycles run away for $\Upsilon P \leq 0.92$ and are stabilised for $\Upsilon P \geq 3.1$, consistent with the criterion $\Upsilon P \gtrsim \ln \mu = 2.33$ (P the period, μ the energy multiplier). Stabilised cycles keep a constant entropy after a one-time increase of 3×10^{-3}; runaway cycles produce entropy without bound (a factor 9×10^{89} in ten cycles for $\Upsilon P = 0.31$), which is the entropy problem of cyclic models [9, 10].

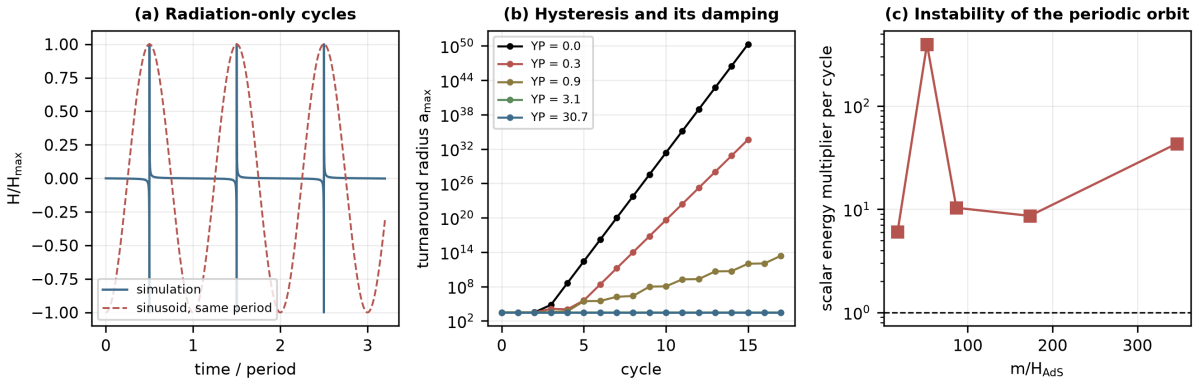


Figure 11: Option B. (a) Hubble rate over three cycles with radiation alone (simulated at $|V_t| = 10^{-6}$, $\rho_c = 1$ in Planck units) against a sinusoid of the same period. (b) Turnaround radius against the cycle number for a scalar excitation with dissipation ΥP from 0 to 31: runaway (hysteresis) below $\ln \mu$, periodic above. (c) Energy multiplier of a scalar perturbation per cycle against m/H_{AdS}.

The amplification is not a numerical artifact. The equations are integrated continuously through every bounce, with no reset. The energy multiplier agrees to 3×10^{-2} among an explicit eighth-order Runge–Kutta method at two tolerances and two maximum steps, an implicit Radau method and LSODA (relative tolerance at most 10^{-10}); at 10^{-9} it is 21% low because the phase of the field at the bounce is no longer resolved. Across the bounces the largest step-to-step change of the density is 6×10^{-4} of its scale, the constraint residual is at most 3×10^{-10} and the residual of the continuity equation at most 2×10^{-6}. The growth obeys an energy-balance law: the continuity equation gives $\Delta(\rho a^3) = -W_n$ with $W_n = \oint p \, d(a^3)$ over a cycle, and at a turnaround $\rho a^3 = -3 a_{\max}$, so that $\Delta a_{\max,n} = W_n/3$. The simulations satisfy it to 2×10^{-3} while the turnaround is curvature dominated (at larger radii the turnaround energy hoa^3 is a cancellation below the integration precision); the loop integral is dominated by the scalar, which is what does the work. Once the scalar dominates, the turnaround occurs at $\rho \simeq 0$ and the cycles grow by a constant factor, $G_n = a_{\max,n+1}/a_{\max,n} \simeq 6.2 \times 10^3$ in the run shown, a law of the hysteresis type [49].

Over 100 or more cycles the grid of masses m, dissipation ΥP from 0 to 10 and initial amplitudes 10^{-8} and 10^{-3} gives 17 stable and 33 growing solutions out of 50 (Fig. 12b); none shrinks, none loses its turnaround, and the boundary follows $\Upsilon P \approx \ln \mu$. Stable solutions stay stable over 1000 cycles, with $|G_n - 1| \leq 3 \times 10^{-7}$ over the last 500, as does the radiation-only control. The instability does not depend on the bounce prescription: with $H^2 = (\rho/3)(1 - (\rho/\rho_c)^2)$ the multiplier is 5.4, and it is 64 for $\rho_c = 10$, 51 for $|V_t| = 10^{-4}$ and 182 for $|V_t| = 10^{-8}$; for $\rho_c = 0.1$ it is 0.64, a window in which the scalar is damped without dissipation, so that the multiplier

depends on the phase with which the field crosses the bounce and is not a fixed number.

Vacuum transitions during the cycles were added in the semiclassical regime only. Excluding the epochs with $R_b|H| > 0.1$ removes 2×10^{-4} of the four-volume of a cycle for $R_b = 10$ (the bounce is short and the scale factor is small there), so the transition probability per cycle is $1 - \exp(-\Gamma V_{4,\mathrm{cyc}})$ with essentially the whole cycle four-volume (Model B). A transition to a vacuum deeper by $|V_t|/2$ at a turnaround, with the energy either thermalised (Model C1) or left in a displaced field (Model C2), turns a stable sequence ($\Upsilon P = 3$, $G_n = 1$) into a growing one ($G_n \simeq 4.85$ and 4.80): the deeper vacuum shortens the period, which lowers ΥP, and raises the multiplier, which moves the cycle across the stability boundary. The transition destabilises the cycles rather than regulating them (Fig. 12c).

For the physical case the scalings give, with $\rho_c = 0.41\rho_{\mathrm{Pl}}$, a bounce temperature of 4.0×10^{18} GeV: the hot epoch of each cycle comes from compression at the bounce, not from the energy of the tunneling. The period is 31 Gyr for $|V_t| = \rho_\Lambda$ and 7.8 Gyr for $|V_t| = 15.7\rho_\Lambda$. Four obstacles remain. First, every cycle has negative vacuum energy, so none contains an accelerating epoch like the observed one. Second, nothing returns the field to the positive-energy vacuum: in the CDL formalism up-tunneling needs a de Sitter parent [50], and the hot bounce restores the symmetric phase from which the field rolls into the true vacuum for $c \geq 0$ (Section 4.6). Third, the tunneling formalism does not apply near the bounce, where the background changes on the time $1/H$ while the bubble has the size R_b, with $R_b H = 4 \times 10^{31}$. Fourth, the bounce itself is an effective description at Planck density. The quantum event is therefore a single trigger, the decay into anti-de Sitter, followed by classical cycles; tunneling does not recur at each zero crossing, and a transition at every bounce would in any case be probabilistic. Table 14 summarises the tests.

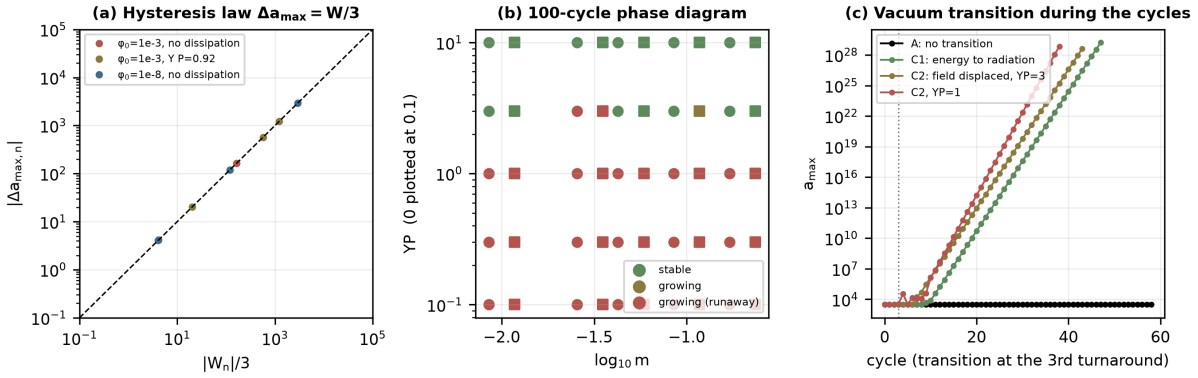


Figure 12: Validation and long-term behaviour of Option B. (a) Change of the turnaround radius against the pressure-volume loop $W_n/3$ for the curvature-dominated cycles of three runs; the dashed line is the law $\Delta a_{\max} = W/3$. (b) Classification after 100 or more cycles over the mass and the dissipation (circles $\varphi_0 = 10^{-8}$, squares 10^{-3}). (c) A vacuum transition at the third turnaround turns a stable sequence into a growing one.

Table 14: Tests of an oscillating universe in the same region (Option B), with an effective loop-quantum-cosmology bounce and the turnaround from a decay to anti-de Sitter.

Test	Success condition	Result
Oscillation	repeated expansion and contraction	yes: periodic with radiation alone, period $\propto \lvert V_t\rvert^{-1/2}$
Nonsingular bounce	$a_{\min} > 0$, finite curvature	yes, with the effective bound $\rho \leq \rho_c$ (not derived here)
Vacuum transition	a physically justified rate	once (the decay to $V_t < 0$, Section 4); no transition near the bounce ($R_b H = 4 \times 10^{31}$) and no return to $V > 0$
Reheating	radiation after the bounce	yes, by compression ($T_b \sim 4 \times 10^{18}$ GeV), independent of the tunneling
Energy conservation	small constraint residual	residual $\leq 3 \times 10^{-5}$
Entropy	consistent across cycles	constant if dissipation stabilises; unbounded growth otherwise
Stability	cycles persist under perturbations	no: scalar energy $\times$6–396 per cycle; stable only for $\Upsilon P \gtrsim \ln \mu$ (stable cases hold 1000 cycles)
Hysteresis law	growth explained quantitatively	$\Delta a_{\max} = W_n/3$ (curvature-dominated turnarounds), constant G_n once the scalar dominates
Transition during the cycles	regulates or destabilises	destabilises: a stable sequence becomes growing ($G_n \simeq 4.9$)
Observed universe in a cycle	a long epoch with $\rho_\Lambda > 0$	no: every cycle has $V < 0$

6 Matter dilution as the trigger: from a held vacuum to a cyclic hot big bang

6.1 How strongly must matter couple? A first-order estimate

The original motivation for a late-time transition was that dilution of matter reduces environmental decoherence and thereby permits a macroscopic quantum transition. In the baseline model nothing of the kind appears: the potential $V(\varphi)$, hence B, does not depend on the matter density, and the Gibbons–Hawking temperature $T_H = H/2\pi = 1.9 \times 10^{-43}$ GeV [51] is 6×10^{-32} of the field scale; thermal-type corrections to B are of relative size $\sim g\,(\kappa \simeq 3.5)$, that is 10^{-59} (Section 3.4). A dependence on matter must be introduced by a coupling, and a conclusion that held only for one coupling would be weak. The requirement can be stated without choosing one.

Any coupling of non-relativistic matter of mass $m_{\rm mat}(\varphi)$ adds $\rho_m \ln m_{\rm mat}(\varphi)$ to the effective potential, so that the energy difference between the vacua changes by $\rho_m \Delta \ln m$, where $\Delta \ln m$ is the fractional change of the matter mass between the two field values and $\rho_m = (\Omega_m/\Omega_\Lambda)V_f$ today. Write $\varepsilon_m \equiv \rho_m \Delta \ln m / \Delta V$ for the relative shift. To first order in the tilt shift $\Delta\eta$,

$$\frac{\Delta\eta}{\eta} = \frac{2\,\delta(\eta)}{\eta\,(x_f - x_t)}\,\varepsilon_m, \qquad \Delta B = B \left|\frac{d\ln b}{d\ln \eta}\right| \frac{\Delta\eta}{\eta} \tag{18}$$

with $\delta(\eta) = \Delta V/(\lambda f^4)$ of Eq. (3). A change of the rate by a factor e needs $\Delta B = 1$; moving a benchmark from $B = 441$ to the critical action $B_c = 287$ needs $\Delta B = 154$ ($\Delta B = 13.7$ for $\eta = 0.32$). With $|d\ln b/d\ln\eta| = 5.5$ at $\eta = 0.30$ this gives $\Delta \ln m = 8.9 \times 10^{-4}$ and 1.4×10^{-1}

respectively: the matter mass must differ by between about 0.1% and 10% between the two vacua. Table 15 translates this to specific couplings.

Table 15: Requirement on a matter coupling that changes the rate by a factor e (left end) or moves the benchmark into the reset window (right end).

Coupling	Requirement	Comment
General	$\Delta \ln m \geq 8.9 \times 10^{-4}$ to 1.4×10^{-1}	independent of the coupling function; $\eta = 0.30$
Linear, $m = m_0 e^{\beta\varphi/M_{\rm Pl}}$	$\beta \geq 3.7 \times 10^{26}$ to 5.7×10^{28} (for $\eta = 0.32$: 4.7×10^{26} to 6.4×10^{27})	$\Delta\varphi/M_{\rm Pl} = 2.4 \times 10^{-30}$; unscreened tests restrict $\beta \lesssim O(1)$; screening (chameleon type) lowers the local coupling, not the cosmological one [35]
Quadratic, $m = m_0(1 + \varphi^2/2\Lambda_q^2)$	$\Lambda_q \leq 58$ to 5 meV ($\eta = 0.30$)	$f = 3.0$ meV, so $\Lambda_q \sim$ (2–20)f: a new interaction at the scale of the potential; symmetron-type screening [36] can hide it in dense environments
Density-dependent effective potential	same $\Delta \ln m$	the model is then specified by $\rho_m F(\varphi)$ with F changing by that amount across $\Delta\varphi$

The conclusion is therefore conditional. For the simplest linear coupling the required strength lies 26 to 28 orders of magnitude above what unscreened laboratory and solar-system tests allow. Quadratic or screened couplings are not excluded by this paper: they evade local tests by construction, but they are tuned, because they require a coupling scale of the same size as the dark-energy potential and a mass change of at least 0.1% of the matter between vacua. The dilution of matter can act as a trigger only through such an added, tuned structure, not through the framework itself. A noise-assisted mechanism would need an explicit open-system influence functional and a calculated change of the tunneling exponent, which is not assumed here.

6.2 A vacuum held by matter

The estimate above concerns a coupling that changes a tunneling rate. A stronger form of the trigger is a coupling that holds the vacuum itself in place while the matter density is high, so that dilution releases it classically. The minimal realization couples the scalar conformally to dark matter only (baryons and radiation are uncoupled, which avoids the stringent visible-sector fifth-force tests),

$$S = \int d^4x\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2 R}{2} - \frac{1}{2}(\nabla\varphi)^2 - V_0(\varphi)\right] + S_{\rm dm}\left[A^2(\varphi)g_{\mu\nu}, \psi_{\rm dm}\right] \tag{19}$$

For pressureless dark matter the conserved density $\rho_* = \rho_{*,0}a^{-3}$ enters the field equation through the effective potential, and the physical dark-matter density is $A(\varphi)\rho_*$ [52, 36]. With

$$V_0(\varphi) = V_c - \frac{\mu^2}{2}\varphi^2 + \frac{\lambda}{4}\varphi^4, \qquad A(\varphi) = 1 + \frac{\varphi^2}{2M^2}, \qquad V_{\rm eff} = V_0 + \rho_* A(\varphi) \tag{20}$$

the effective mass at the symmetric point is $m_{\rm eff}^2 = \rho_*/M^2 - \mu^2$. The point $\varphi = 0$, with vacuum energy $V_c > 0$, is held while $\rho_* > \rho_{\rm crit} = \mu^2 M^2$ and released when the expansion dilutes the matter below it, at

$$a_c = \left(\frac{\rho_{*,0}}{\mu^2 M^2}\right)^{1/3}, \qquad V_c - V_0(v) = \frac{\mu^2 v^2}{4} = \frac{A(v)-1}{2}\,\rho_{\rm crit} \tag{21}$$

This is the symmetron form [36, 53] with two changes: the coupling is to dark matter, and the broken vacua $\varphi = \pm v$, $v^2 = \mu^2/\lambda$, carry negative energy $V_0(v) = -qV_c$. Today $V_c = 3\Omega_\Lambda H_0^2 M_{\rm Pl}^2$, so the model reproduces the observed dark energy while it is held, and $a_c > 1$ is required for it to be held now. The second relation is exact and has a consequence that cannot be avoided: the vacuum energy given up at the release equals half the coupling energy stored at the critical density, and since $\rho_{\rm crit} < \rho_{\rm dm,0} < V_c$, a release into a negative vacuum needs $A(v) - 1 > 2V_c/\rho_{\rm crit}$, i.e. the dark-matter mass must grow severalfold once the field rolls ($A(v) = 85$ for $a_c = 2$, $q = 1$; 6.1–7.2 $\times 10^3$ over the parameter grid below). At $\varphi = 0$ the coupling $\beta = M_{\rm Pl}\, d\ln A/d\varphi$ vanishes, so there is no fifth force today. Fig. 13a shows the effective potential as the matter dilutes.

The background equations (flat, general relativity) are

$$3M_{\rm Pl}^2 H^2 = \rho_r + \rho_b + A\rho_* + \frac{\dot\varphi^2}{2} + V_0, \qquad \ddot\varphi + 3H\dot\varphi + V_0' + \rho_* A' = 0, \qquad \dot\rho_* = -3H\rho_* \tag{22}$$

with $\dot H = -(\frac{4}{3}\rho_r + \rho_b + A\rho_* + \dot\varphi^2)/2M_{\rm Pl}^2$. Total stress-energy is conserved: the scalar and the coupled matter exchange energy through A', and the coupling energy is counted once, in $A\rho_*$. They are integrated from recombination ($z = 1100$) with the field at the de Sitter quantum floor, $\varphi_0 = 10^{-60} v$ (about $H/2\pi$ in Planck units), in units of H_0 and $M_{\rm Pl}$ (dilution_background.py).

6.3 Release and recollapse

Three models are compared with identical initial data: ΛCDM (A), the uncoupled scalar with the same potential (B, the control) and the coupled scalar (C). For the reference case $a_c = 2$, $\mu = 100H_0$, $q = 1$ (Fig. 13), ΛCDM expands forever. The coupled field stays at $|\varphi|/v = 4.2 \times 10^{-64}$ up to the present, so the past history is that of ΛCDM ($w_0 = -1$ to all digits; $H(a)$ agrees with ΛCDM to the integration accuracy), is released after a_c, rolls at $a = 8.25$ and turns the expansion around at $a = 10.64$, 46 Gyr from now; the total density reaches zero there and the contraction follows. The uncoupled control has been unstable since recombination and turns around at $a = 2.05$, 17 Gyr from now.

The comparison the trigger has to pass is C against B. Over a grid of 100 coupled models ($a_c = 1.25$–5, $\mu = 3$–$300H_0$, q from -0.5 to 10) every one reaches the present with the vacuum held; 75 release into a negative vacuum and recollapse, and the 25 with $q < 0$ settle in a lower de Sitter vacuum and expand forever (Fig. 14b, Table 16). The control rolls before today for $\mu \geq 300H_0$, so it cannot describe the observed universe there, while the coupled model can at every μ. The coupling is what makes a late release compatible with an observed ΛCDM past. The release is not instantaneous: the field grows from the quantum floor at a rate of order μ,

so the roll lags a_c by about $\ln(v/\varphi_0)/\mu$ Hubble times, from $a = 2.69$ to 8.25 for seeds 10^{-6} to $10^{-60}v$; the control rolls before today for every seed above $10^{-40}v$ (Fig. 14c). Large μ makes the release a sharp trigger at a_c.

Table 16: Release and turnaround of the coupled model and the uncoupled control ($a_c = 2$, $q = 1$, seed $10^{-60}v$ at $z = 1100$). Times from today; $A(v)$ is the factor by which the dark-matter mass grows after the release.

μ/H_0	roll, a	turnaround, a	turnaround (Gyr)	control turnaround, a	$A(v)$
3	1.63e+26	1.88e+26	1061	4.28e+24	85
10	1.76e+06	2.09e+06	259	2.84e+05	85
30	156	195	96	34.9	85
100	8.25	10.6	46	2.05	85
300	3.57	4.7	32	rolled before today	85

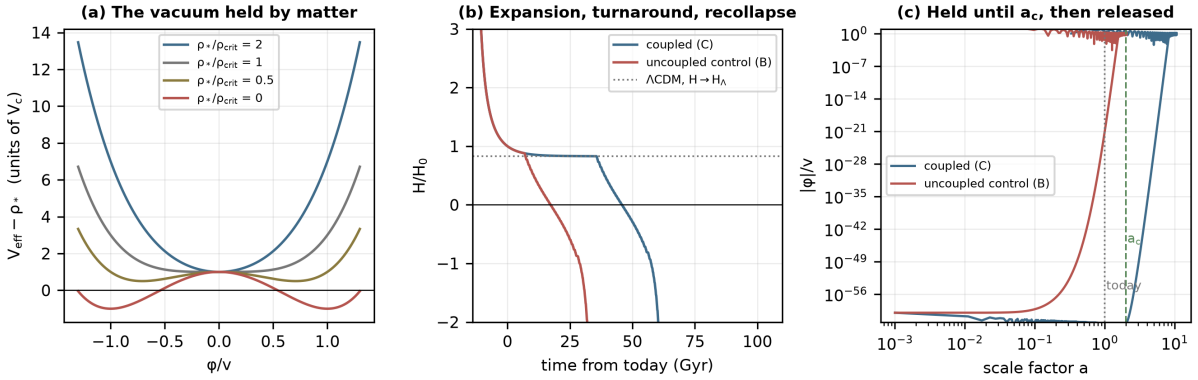


Figure 13: The matter-held vacuum ($a_c = 2$, $\mu = 100H_0$, $q = 1$). (a) Effective potential for several matter densities; the symmetric point, with energy V_c, is a minimum while $\rho_* > \rho_{\rm crit}$. (b) Hubble rate against time from today for the coupled model, the uncoupled control and ΛCDM. (c) Field amplitude from recombination: the coupled field is held at the quantum floor until a_c, the control grows from the start.

6.4 Cooling or dilution?

A thermal mass $cT^2\varphi^2/2$ from a bath of temperature T acts in the same way: the symmetric point is held while $\rho_*/\rho_{\rm crit} + (T/T_c)^2 > 1$, $T_c = \mu/\sqrt{c}$, and the three possible triggers are compared in Fig. 14a. With the critical scale factor set to 2 for each, matter alone releases the field at $a = 2$, temperature alone at $a = 2$, both together at $a = 2.65$, and all three recollapse ($a = 10.6$, 11.9 and 14.9). The thermal free energy is used in its saturating form, $V_T = (cT^2\varphi^2/2)/(1+c\varphi^2/2T^2)$, which follows the high-temperature result while the bath particles are light and the free energy of the species ($\sim T^4$) when they become heavy; the truncated quadratic form fails during the roll.

Mathematically, then, cooling could trigger the release; physically it cannot. In physical units $\sqrt{c} = \mu a_T/T_0$, so a release at $a_T \sim 2$ with $\mu = 100H_0$ needs $\sqrt{c} = 1.2 \times 10^{-27}$, and a scalar with so weak a coupling interacts with the bath at a rate $\sim c^2T \approx 4 \times 10^{-79}\,H_0$: it never reaches equilibrium, and the thermal mass is never established. A coupling strong enough for

equilibrium today, $\sqrt{c} > 5 \times 10^{-8}$, holds the field until $a_T \sim 8 \times 10^{19}$. The two requirements exclude each other by twenty orders of magnitude, and the CMB photons couple to a neutral scalar only through higher-dimension operators whose thermal mass falls faster still. Cooling does not trigger the release; dilution of dark matter can. This complements the result of Section 4.8 that cooling cannot raise the tunneling probability.

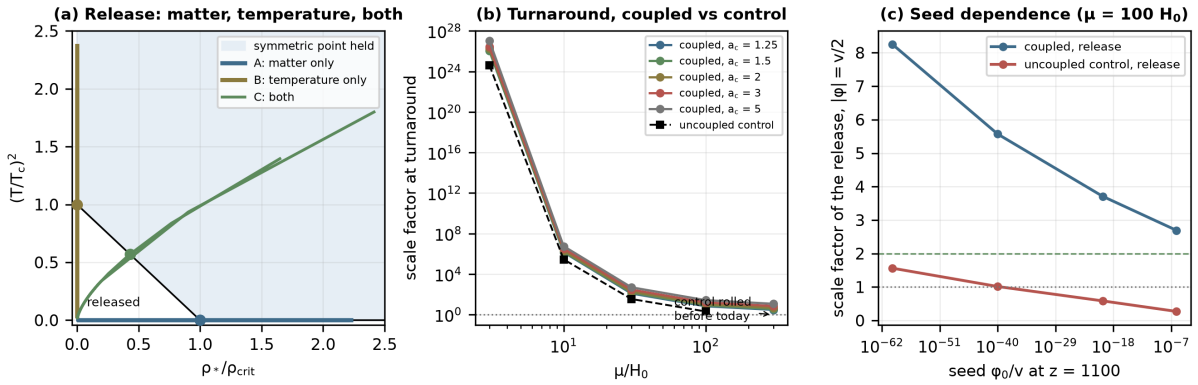


Figure 14: (a) The plane of matter density and temperature: the symmetric point is held above the line; trajectories of the matter-only, temperature-only and combined triggers (dots: release). (b) Scale factor at turnaround against μ for the coupled model at five a_c and for the uncoupled control, which rolls before today at $\mu = 300H_0$. (c) Scale factor of the release against the initial seed for the coupled model and the control.

6.5 The tunneling branch: dilution can open the survival window

When the coupling is centred on the false vacuum of Section 2, $A = 1 + (\varphi - \varphi_f)^2/2M^2$, matter deepens the false minimum and raises the barrier, and in the dimensionless family the potential becomes $p(x) + \theta(x-1)^2/2$ with $\theta = \rho_*/(\lambda f^2 M^2) \propto a^{-3}$ (density_bounce.py). Above a degeneracy density $\theta_{\rm deg}(\eta)$ the matter-held state is the true vacuum; below it, it is metastable, and the bounce action falls from infinity toward its vacuum value as matter dilutes (Fig. 15a; at $\theta = 0$ the table of Section 3 is reproduced to 2×10^{-12}). Dilution can therefore only switch on a vacuum instability that the potential already contains, never exceed it, but it changes which vacua are allowed. The survival integral of Section 4.2 is evaluated with the time-dependent rate: a vacuum with $B_0 = 150$, excluded without the coupling by a factor e^{137}, survives with it ($\ln I = -115$ for $\theta_0 = 0.3\theta_{\rm deg}$, $\eta = 0.2$) and reaches one nucleation per Hubble four-volume at $a_* = 1.10$; for $B_0 = 287$ the trigger point moves to $a_* = 2.9$–11.7, and for $B_0 = 400$ the rate never reaches H^4 (Fig. 15b, c). The coupling turns the window below B_c, which survival excludes for a matter-independent rate, into a future trigger. Two limits are stated rather than extrapolated through: the homogeneous mean density applies to a bubble larger than the scale of matter inhomogeneity, and near the classical threshold the barrier vanishes and the instanton approximation fails (for $\eta > \eta_c$ the matter-held minimum exists only for $0.019 < \theta < 0.263$ at $\eta = 0.40$ and the release is classical).

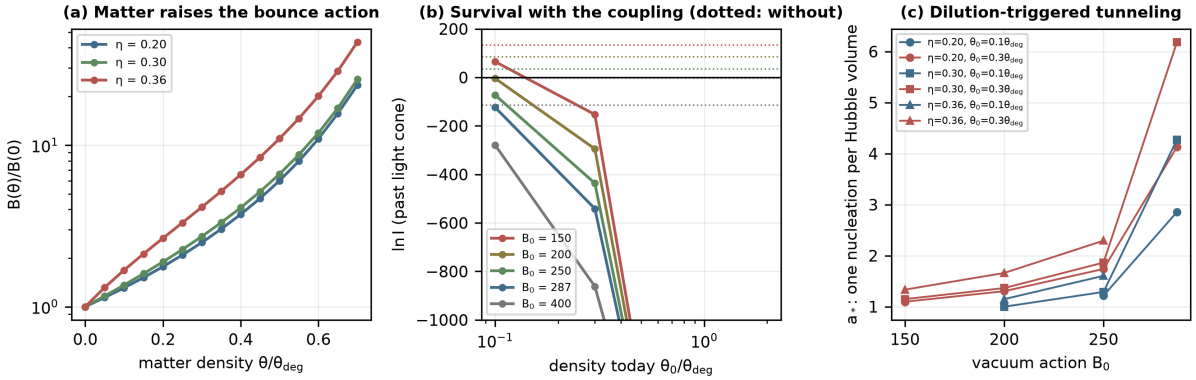


Figure 15: Tunneling branch. (a) Bounce action against the matter density, relative to its vacuum value, for three tilts. (b) Expected number of nucleations in the past light cone with the coupling, against the density today, for vacuum actions $B_0 = 150$–400 (dotted: without the coupling). (c) Scale factor at which one nucleation per Hubble four-volume is reached, for the surviving cases.

6.6 From recollapse to a cyclic hot big bang

A recollapse becomes a cycle only if the contraction reverses, which needs physics beyond general relativity; the effective loop-quantum-cosmology equations for a flat universe, for which they are derived [46, 47],

$$H^2 = \frac{\rho}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(1-\frac{\rho}{\rho_c}\right), \qquad \dot{H} = -\frac{\rho+p}{2M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(1-\frac{2\rho}{\rho_c}\right) \tag{23}$$

are used as the bounce, with no curvature term appended (cyclic_extension.py, hot_cycles.py). The physical $\rho_c \sim \rho_{\rm Pl}$ is $10^{122}V_c$ and cannot be integrated; ρ_c is varied and the dependence on it reported. A bounce alone is not enough. Without dissipation the contraction is dominated by the scalar's kinetic energy, which grows as a^{-6}, faster than radiation, and the bounce occurs at low density and is cold: at $\rho_c = 10^4 V_c$ the cycles repeat with $G_n \simeq 0.99$ and each has a vacuum-dominated phase, but no hot dense epoch, and they grow ($G_n \simeq 1.19$ and 2.31) at $\rho_c = 10^5$ and $10^6 V_c$, the hysteresis of Section 5.6. A constant dissipation Υ heats the bounce but fills the next cycle with radiation, and the vacuum fraction falls cycle by cycle (from 0.75 to 0.08 over six cycles at $\Upsilon = 0.1H_0$): the energy released by the vacuum, once thermalized, swamps the matter that would hold the next vacuum, by the factor $\Delta V/\rho_{\rm crit} = (A(v)-1)/2$ of Section 6.2.

Two pieces of standard early-universe physics remove both failures. The first is thermal dissipation, $\Upsilon = C_T T^3$, the form used for dissipative scalar dynamics in warm inflation [54]: it is negligible in the cold expanding universe and dominant in the hot contraction, where it turns the scalar's energy into radiation, so the bounce is radiation dominated and hot. The second is that the dark-matter abundance is not an initial condition but is set by thermal freeze-out as a fixed ratio to the entropy [55]. A bounce hotter than the dark-matter mass returns the dark matter to equilibrium, and as the bath cools after the bounce freeze-out restores the same ratio. The same coupling then restores the vacuum: while the dark matter is relativistic its field-dependent mass gives the scalar a thermal mass $m^2T^2/12M^2$, which exceeds H once $T \lesssim mM_{\rm Pl}/6M$, long

before freeze-out at $T \sim m/20$, and damps the field toward $\varphi = 0$ (high-temperature symmetry restoration). The resulting oscillation is 10^3–10^9 times faster than the expansion and is applied through its adiabatic result; the matter era that follows is integrated explicitly. In the equations, the comoving matter is reset at freeze-out ($T_{\rm fo} = 5T_{\rm eq}$) to $N_{\rm dm} = \kappa_{\rm dm} S$, $N_b = \kappa_b S$, with $S = a^3 \rho_r^{3/4}$ and κ fixed by the present universe, the energy taken from the bath; the bounce must be hotter than $T_{\rm fo}$, which needs $\rho_c \gtrsim 10^{13} V_c$ and is satisfied with a margin of 30 orders of magnitude by the physical ρ_c.

With these, the cycles are self-similar (Fig. 16, Table 17). In the reference run ($a_c = 2$, $\mu = 30H_0$, $q = 1$, $\rho_c = 10^{14} V_c$, $C_T = 1$) every cycle after ours has a radiation-dominated bounce (radiation fraction 1.0000 at the bounce), a matter era (matter fraction 0.996 at its peak), a dark-energy epoch with the field held (vacuum fraction 0.9999, 3.63 e-folds of accelerated expansion, against about half an e-fold in our universe so far), a release at the same temperature in every cycle ($T_{\rm rel} = 0.0208$ in units where $T_0 = 0.1285$ today) and a turnaround. From the second cycle on, these values agree from cycle to cycle to five digits or better. The second law is satisfied, not evaded: the radiation entropy grows by a factor 1.25×10^7 per cycle, and because the matter-to-entropy ratio and therefore the whole thermal history as a function of temperature are reset, the entropy does not accumulate in the local state but enlarges the next cycle, $G_n = a_{{\rm max},n+1}/a_{{\rm max},n} = 231.80 = (S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/3} = 231.80$ (Tolman's growing cycles [9] with a fixed local history). The constraint of the effective equations is satisfied to 2×10^{-10}, enforced by projection whenever the scale factor doubles (the largest correction 1×10^{-8}), because a violation would otherwise act as a spurious cosmological constant.

Table 17: Hot cycles: values of the second cycle (identical in later cycles for the completed runs). Reference: $a_c = 2$, $\mu = 30H_0$, $q = 1$, $\rho_c = 10^{14} V_c$, $C_T = 1$; other rows change one parameter. The two controls fail: without the freeze-out reset the matter-to-entropy ratio falls by the entropy growth every cycle and no matter era or dark-energy epoch remains; without dissipation the bounce is cold and kinetic dominated and the cycles run away.

Run	radiation at bounce	peak matter fraction	held e-folds	$T_{\rm rel}$	G_n	$(S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/}$
reference	1.000	0.996	3.63	0.0208	231.8	231.8
no freeze-out reset	1.000	0.002	0.00	none	–	–
no dissipation ($C_T = 0$)	0.000	0.000	0.00	0.0000	runaway	–
$C_T = 0.1$	1.000	0.996	2.89	0.0121	111.8	111.8
$C_T = 10$	1.000	0.996	4.33	0.1598	541.4	541.4
$\rho_c = 10^{15} V_c$	1.000	0.996	3.65	0.0207	238.2	238.2
$\rho_c = 10^{16} V_c$	1.000	0.996	3.66	0.0206	240.3	240.3
$\mu = 100$	1.000	0.996	2.12	0.0283	51.3	51.3
$q = 0.3$	1.000	0.996	3.59	0.0155	211.8	211.8
$a_c = 3$	1.000	0.996	4.07	0.0190	361.6	361.6

6.7 What the cycle requires and how it can fail

The calculation identifies four ingredients, each necessary: a vacuum held by matter and released by dilution (which gives the dark-energy epoch and the turnaround), a nonsingular bounce, dissipation that thermalizes the scalar energy in the hot contraction, and re-thermalization with freeze-out that resets the matter-to-entropy ratio and, through the same coupling, the vacuum.

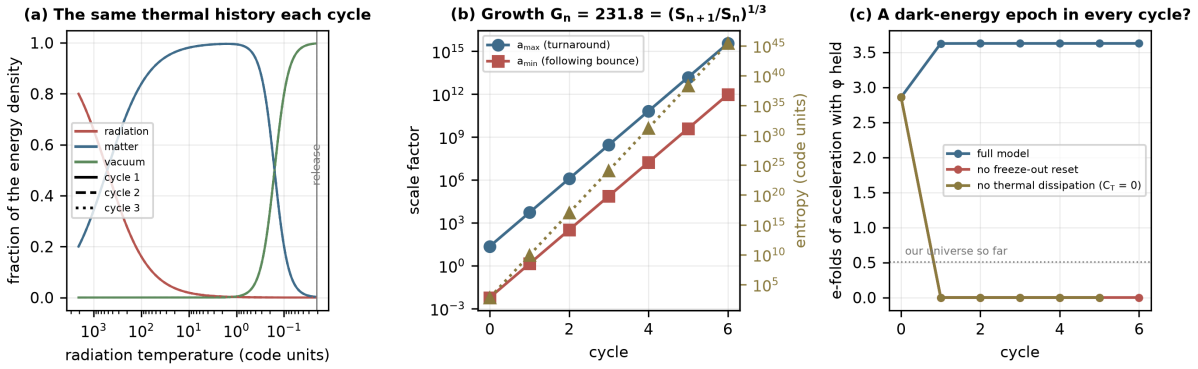


Figure 16: Hot cycles (reference run). (a) Fractions of radiation, matter and vacuum energy against the radiation temperature in three successive cycles, up to the release; the curves coincide. (b) Turnaround and bounce scale factors and the radiation entropy per cycle: the growth factor equals $(S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/3}$. (c) E-folds of accelerated expansion with the field held, per cycle, for the full model and the two controls.

Removing the third or the fourth destroys the cycle (Table 17). The result does not depend on the details within the ranges tested: $C_T = 0.1$–10, $\rho_c = 10^{14}$–$10^{16} V_c$ (with $G_n = 231.8$, 238.2 and 240.3, converging), $\mu = 30$ and $100 H_0$, $q = 0.3$ and 1, $a_c = 2$ and 3.

The model makes statements that can be tested now. The dark energy is exactly a cosmological constant until the release ($w = -1$), so a confirmed evolution of the dark energy at the level suggested by recent baryon-acoustic-oscillation analyses [56] would disfavor it. The coupling vanishes at $\varphi = 0$, so there is no fifth force in the cosmological background or in collapsed structures. The weakest point is the deepest voids: a void with density below $\rho_{\rm crit} = \rho_{\rm dm,0}/a_c^3$ (1/8 of the mean for $a_c = 2$) and radius larger than the Compton length π/μ (~ 140 Mpc for $\mu = 100 H_0$) would release the vacuum locally today and form domain walls; for $\mu \gtrsim 300 H_0$ and $a_c \lesssim 2$ the largest, emptiest voids reach that condition, which bounds the parameter space from void statistics. In the future, the dark-matter mass grows by $A(v)$ after the release and the recollapse follows within tens of Gyr (Table 16).

The limits are equally definite. The bounce is an effective prescription, not a derivation; ρ_c is 10^{108} times below the Planck value in the simulations; the hot-phase restoration is applied through its adiabatic result and freeze-out is instantaneous; the dynamics are homogeneous, so the growth of inhomogeneities and anisotropies in the contraction, which can dominate a contracting universe, is not followed; and $a_c \sim 1$ requires $\mu^2 M^2 \approx \rho_{\rm dm,0}$, a coincidence of the same kind as that of the cosmological constant. The calculation shows that a cyclic hot big bang is consistent within this model with the stated ingredients, and which ingredients it cannot do without; it does not show that the universe is cyclic.

7 Consistency conditions and falsification tests

A model of this class must satisfy internal consistency conditions, which are mathematical or follow from the framework, and it can be confronted with observational tests. The two are kept apart because failing the first means the model is ill-defined, while failing the second means that

it is disfavored by data. All are computed in this paper and can be recomputed for a different potential with the supplied code.

7.1 Internal consistency conditions

- C1 (existence). A metastable minimum requires $\eta < \eta_c = 0.385$; for larger tilt there is nothing to decay.
- C2 (semiclassical validity). The loop expansion parameter $1/B$ must be small. All draws with $B < 30$ (2.5% of the prior) have rates far above the survival bound, so the classification of allowed draws is unaffected (Section 4.3).
- C3 (negative mode and flat limit). The bounce has one negative mode and gravity enters as an $O(g)$ perturbation, $g \sim 10^{-60}$ (Section 3.3).
- C4 (energy). With $V_t \geq 0$ the released energy density cannot exceed ρ_Λ, so $T_{\rm reh} \leq 2.2$ meV; with $V_t < 0$ the interior crunches (Section 5.3).
- C5 (geometry). For any sub-Planckian energy the open interior stays curvature dominated, $Y(t) \leq Y(t_0) = 2.0 \times 10^{-63}$, unless it inflates; the single-field potential gives at most 9.3×10^{-62} e-folds (Section 5.3).
- C6 (percolation). A global transition requires $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$ or larger, a window of width $\Delta B = 3.9$ below the survival bound that holds 0.12% of the prior volume.
- C7 (thermal consistency). A scalar in equilibrium with the CMB at redshift z keeps its false minimum only if $c < \theta_c \lambda f^2 / T_\gamma(z)^2$, i.e. $c < 1.1 \times 10^{-5}$ for a bath coupled back to recombination, and the survival condition then applies to the rate history $\Gamma(T_\gamma(t))$ (Section 4.8).
- C8 (repeated transitions). Over any chain of transitions the energy released telescopes, $\sum_i \Delta V_i = \rho_\Lambda - V_{\rm final} \leq \rho_\Lambda$, so a second generation cannot raise the temperature above 2.2 meV (Section 5.5).
- C9 (oscillation). A periodic cycle needs a turnaround (here the decay to $V_t < 0$), a bounce beyond general relativity, and dissipation that removes the scalar energy gained at each bounce, $\Upsilon P \gtrsim \ln \mu$; with these the cycles persist but carry negative vacuum energy throughout (Section 5.6).
- C10 (held vacuum). The vacuum is held today only if $a_c > 1$, i.e. $\mu^2 M^2 < \rho_{\rm dm,0}$, and a release into a negative vacuum needs $A(v) - 1 = 2(V_c - V_0(v))/\rho_{\rm crit} > 2V_c/\rho_{\rm crit}$, a dark-matter mass that grows severalfold after the release (Section 6.2).
- C11 (hot cycles). A cycle with a hot big bang and a dark-energy epoch needs a bounce hotter than dark-matter freeze-out, dissipation that thermalizes the scalar energy in the contraction, and re-thermalization of the dark matter; the entropy then grows each cycle and the cycles grow as $(S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/3}$ with a fixed local history (Section 6.6).

7.2 Observational tests

- O1 (survival). The absence of a bubble in our past light cone requires $\Gamma V_4 < 3.0$, i.e. $\Gamma/H^4 < 51$ at 95% confidence, which excludes 15% of the prior volume of the benchmark family and constrains the future mean decay time only to $t_{\rm dec} \gtrsim 8.2 \times 10^7$ yr.

- O2 (reset window). A transition on cosmological time scales requires $B_c \lesssim B \lesssim B_c + 28$ for decay within 10^{20} yr; this holds for 0.77% of the prior volume. An action above $B_c + 212$ puts the decay beyond 10^{100} yr.

- O3 (hot epoch). A hot universe in the nucleated region requires $\rho_{\rm reh} \gtrsim (1\ {\rm MeV})^4$, which is 1.4×10^{35} times the dark-energy density; the bound of Section 5 excludes it for decay of the present dark energy in this framework.

- O4 (trigger). Matter dilution changes a tunneling rate only for $\Delta \ln m \gtrsim 10^{-3}$ between the vacua (Section 6.1); a vacuum held by a quadratic dark-matter coupling is released classically, has no fifth force while held, and gives $w = -1$ exactly until the release (Sections 6.2–6.3), so a confirmed evolution of the dark energy would disfavor it.

- O7 (voids). A void with density below $\rho_{\rm dm,0}/a_c^3$ and radius above the Compton length π/μ releases the vacuum locally today and forms domain walls; void statistics bound $\mu \gtrsim 300 H_0$ with $a_c \lesssim 2$ (Section 6.7).

- O5 (signals). A solitary transition produces no signal in our patch; bubble collisions [25, 33, 34] require a population and $\Gamma/H^4 = O(1)$ (C6). The vacuum is indistinguishable from a cosmological constant ($w = -1$) until it decays. A measured evolution of the dark energy, which recent baryon-acoustic-oscillation analyses combined with the CMB and supernovae prefer at the level of a few standard deviations depending on the supernova sample [56], would favor a rolling field and not a metastable vacuum. No observational discriminant of the cyclic reset is available from this model.

- O6 (cooling). If the scalar is coupled to the CMB the decay probability was larger in the past and falls as the universe cools: equilibrated scenarios with $c \geq 0$ lift the excluded prior mass from 15% to 24–49% and leave no survival-consistent draw that decays within 10^{20} yr, so the absence of a transition so far constrains the coupling of the scalar to the CMB as well as its potential (Section 4.8).

A tunneling transition producing a successful cosmology would have to lie outside the class of Sections 3–5. It would need a parent vacuum energy of at least $\sim 10^{34}\rho_\Lambda$ and, by Section 5.3, a post-nucleation region that inflates before it reheats. Section 6 shows a different route that does not need tunneling: a vacuum held by matter and released by dilution ends the expansion, and an effective bounce with thermal dissipation and freeze-out starts a hot one; the cyclic models constructed earlier provide a reset by other means [4, 5].

8 Discussion and limitations

- A single scalar field and a quartic-tilt potential are used. Other potentials change $b(\eta)$ and the interior energy fraction, but not the scales: the rate depends on the combination $M_{\rm Pl}^4/V_f$ and the interior energy on V_f, both fixed by the data, so O1, O3 and the geometric argument of Section 5.3 are generic.

- The one-loop prefactor is a systematic uncertainty, not a result; the conclusions are insensitive to it over six decades (Section 4.3).

- The decay is treated as a flat-space process because $g \sim 10^{-60}$; the gravitational code is validated against analytic limits and used for the map of the regime in which gravity matters, which the dark-energy scale excludes.

- The survival criterion assumes a constant rate and a false vacuum throughout the history of the observed universe; a field that evolved or was thermally affected in the early universe would change the early part of the cone, which carries a small part of V_4.

- The interior evolution assumes a homogeneous open slicing and a perturbative decay of the condensate to radiation; bubble-wall collisions can concentrate energy locally, but the average energy density is bounded by ΔV (Table 9).

- Up-tunneling from the false to a higher vacuum, the decay of the true vacuum in curved space [50], thermal activation of the Hawking–Moss type [30] and decays of the present vacuum into other vacua are not considered.

- The priors of the Monte Carlo are documented assumptions, not measurements; the regime fractions describe the sample space of the model, not the probability of a transition in our universe.

- The matter-coupling analysis is first order in the tilt shift and does not simulate any specific screened model.

- The thermal analysis assumes equilibrium with the CMB (an upper bound on the thermal channel), the leading high-temperature term with one coefficient c, and a bath coupled below a stated redshift; it neglects higher-order thermal corrections and the interpolation between the O(4) and O(3) saddles near $T_\times$, which a periodic-instanton calculation would refine.

- The cycles of Section 6 rest on an effective bounce (not a derivation), on ρ_c 108 orders of magnitude below the Planck density (with the dependence reported and converging), on the adiabatic result of the hot-phase restoration and an instantaneous freeze-out, and on homogeneous dynamics: the growth of inhomogeneities and anisotropies during the contraction, which can dominate a contracting universe, is not followed. The value $a_c \sim 1$ requires $\mu^2 M^2 \approx \rho_{\rm dm,0}$, a coincidence like that of the cosmological constant.

- The simulations of Section 5.5 are homogeneous and use a phenomenological dissipation: bubble-wall dynamics, inhomogeneous wall collisions, the microphysics of reheating and

the gravitational backreaction of the wall are not simulated, and the bounce of Option B is an effective loop-quantum-cosmology prescription (with a second prescription as a check), not a derived one.

9 Conclusions

The present dark energy can end the expansion and start a new hot big bang, but not by tunneling. If it is the energy of a vacuum held in place by dark matter, the dilution of the matter releases it into a negative vacuum and the expansion turns around, with a ΛCDM past ($w = -1$, no fifth force) that an uncoupled field cannot reproduce. With an effective bounce, thermal dissipation in the hot contraction and the re-thermalization and freeze-out of dark matter, the cycles are self-similar: each has a radiation-dominated bounce, a matter era, a dark-energy epoch of 3.6 e-folds and a release at the same temperature, and the entropy produced, as the second law requires, enlarges the next cycle by exactly $(S_{n+1}/S_n)^{1/3} = 231.8$. Each ingredient is necessary: without the dissipation or the freeze-out the cycles fail. Cooling cannot replace dilution as the trigger. The remaining sections of this conclusion summarize why the direct route fails, which is what makes these ingredients necessary.

A late-time false-vacuum transition of the present dark energy is a well-defined calculation, and for the explicit potential studied it can be done to a stated precision. The quantum decay is a flat-space process controlled by the action $B = b(\eta)/\lambda$, which must lie near $B_c \approx 287$ for the transition to be neither excluded nor effectively absent; with survival evaluated on the past light cone the bound is weak ($\Gamma/H^4 < 51$) and the window is set by the action itself. Cosmological cooling does not help: a thermal mass rescales the potential exactly, the thermal O(3) channel dominates above 0.18 meV and falls monotonically as the universe cools, and a scalar in equilibrium with the CMB is more strongly constrained (24–49% of the prior excluded against 15%) with no late-time decay window left. The nucleated daughter region carries at most the dark-energy density, reheats to at most 2.2 meV and cools as $1/t$ in a curvature-dominated open universe; this rests on geometry and not on energy conservation alone, holds for any sub-Planckian parent energy and any number of scalar fields, and a trigger by matter dilution would need a change of the matter mass between the vacua of at least 0.1%. A daughter region of the present dark energy is cold and empty, and the cyclic-reset hypothesis, in the form tested, is not supported; the framework identifies what would have to change.

Lorentzian simulations of the daughter region (Section 5.5) support these statements with two fields, dissipation and gravity: the closed-form interior is reproduced to 7%, a reservoir hidden by a negative offset leaves an anti-de Sitter vacuum that crunches after 5.5 s when it reaches 0.7 MeV, flattening at the dark-energy scale needs a vev above $4M_{\rm Pl}$ and reheats below 1.5 meV, and repeated transitions release no more than ρ_Λ in total. A viable hot daughter universe needs a parent vacuum energy at least 1.4×10^{35} times the observed dark energy, which is excluded, or a cancellation of the same size, which ends in a crunch.

The same region can oscillate only with physics beyond general relativity. With an effective bounce, the decay into anti-de Sitter turns expansion into contraction and radiation-only cycles

repeat exactly, but a scalar excitation is amplified at every bounce (by factors between 6.1 and 396 in energy per cycle over the range simulated), the growth of successive cycles obeys $\Delta a_{\max} = W/3$, and the cycles are stable only when the dissipation per cycle exceeds the logarithm of the amplification. A vacuum transition during the cycles pushes them across this boundary. Every cycle has negative vacuum energy and its hot phase comes from compression at a Planck-density bounce, so an oscillating universe of this kind does not contain an epoch like the observed one unless the vacuum is held by matter, as in Section 6.

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Data availability. The data underlying every figure and table (bounce tables, error budget, survival calculation, falsification map, Monte Carlo summary, interior evolution, scope and coupling estimates, verification results) are deposited with the code at https://github.com/sandlerleon/late-time-vacuum-decay and archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23794069.

Code availability. All code (Python, NumPy, SciPy, Matplotlib) is released under the MIT licence at https://github.com/sandlerleon/late-time-vacuum-decay, archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.2
Running the scripts in the stated order regenerates every number in this paper, and verify.py runs 28 executable checks. The manuscript is archived at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23794065.

Authors' contributions. L.S.: conceptualization, methodology, software, formal analysis, investigation, visualization, writing.

Use of generative AI. During the preparation of this work the author used Claude (Anthropic) to assist with the design of the numerical analysis, writing of the code, literature checking and drafting. The author reviewed and edited the content, checked the code against analytic limits and executable tests, verified the cited references, and takes full responsibility for the publication. No AI tool is an author.

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